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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

NATIONAL UNITY DAY MESSAGES

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 11

Friday is the National Unity Day of Nepal. Every year, the government and people observe the day on the Nepali date of Poush 27, which also marks the day late King Prithvi Narayan Shah was born. Shah and his successors are credited with unifying Nepal by conquering the small and scattered states that existed within its borders.

On the occasion, President Ramchandra Paudel issued a message of greeting to all Nepalis inside and outside the country. "The unification campaign, initiated by Prithvi Narayan Shah and continued by our brave ancestors, laid the foundation for our independent, indivisible, sovereign, federal democratic republic of Nepal today," he said in the message. The President further hoped that the unity day would inspire everyone to work for the people's happiness and prosperity while emphasising the independence, sovereignty, geographical integrity and national unity of our country.

Similarly, Vice President Ramsahay Prasad Yadav also extended best wishes and stressed that only national unity could deliver development, peace, prosperity and territorial integrity. "Quarrels, disputes and conflicts weaken states. That is why everyone must be aware and alert about this," he advised.

The Vice President felt that Nepal's beauty came from its diversity and hoped that this beauty could be integrated into the national spirit.

Former President Bidya Devi Bhandari also paid tribute to the great personalities who contributed to the campaign to build Nepal in her statement issued for the day.

IRISH UPPER HOUSE CHIEF CALLS ON PRESIDENT

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 11

Cathaoirleach of Ireland's Seanad Éireann Jerry Buttimer paid a courtesy call on President Ramchandra Paudel on Thursday. As per a statement issued by the President's Office, President Paudel stressed the need to strengthen the already friendly relations maintained by Nepal and Ireland and cooperate on matters of mutual interest on bilateral, regional and multilateral fora.

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Today's Supplement Highlight

Empower women, drive progress.





PHOTO: RSS

Women in traditional Tharu attire participating in a procession taken out in connection with Ratnanagar Festival-2080 in Tikauli, Chitwan on Thursday.

Remittance growth helping external sector of economy

BY LAXMAN KAFLE
Kathmandu, Jan. 11



A significant boost in remittance inflows has resulted in further improvement in the external sector of the country's economy.

The country has seen improving foreign currency reserves, balance of payment, current account and remittance inflows until mid-December of the current fiscal year 2023/24.

The current macroeconomic and financial report based on five months of the current fiscal year made public by Nepal Rastra Bank (NRB) on Thursday showed that there has been further improvement in foreign currency reserves, remittance inflows, current account and balance of payment.

Foreign exchange reserves reach all-time high of Rs. 1,767 billion

According to the report, the foreign current reserves reached an all-time high of Rs. 1,767 billion during the first five months of the current fiscal year.

The gross foreign exchange reserves increased by 14.8 per cent to Rs. 1,767.04 billion in mid-December 2023 from Rs.1539.36 billion in mid-July 2023.

In US dollar terms, the gross foreign exchange reserves increased by 13.6 per cent to 13.31 billion in mid-December 2023 from 11.71 billion in mid-July 2023.

Of the total foreign exchange reserves, reserves held by NRB increased by 15.6 per cent to Rs. 1,556.25 billion in mid-December 2023 from Rs.1345.78 billion in mid-July 2023.

Reserves held by banks and financial institutions (except NRB) increased by 8.9 per cent to Rs. 210.79 billion in mid-December 2023 from Rs.193.59 billion in mid-July 2023.

The share of Indian currency in total reserves stood at 21.6 per cent in mid-December 2023.

Based on the imports of five months of 2023/24, the foreign exchange reserves of the banking sector are sufficient to cover the prospective merchandise imports of 14.1 months and merchandise and services imports of 11.8 months, said the NRB.

Remittance inflows rose by 27.6%

According to the report, remittance inflows increased by 27.6 per cent to Rs. 613.25 billion in the review period compared to an increase of 23 per cent in the same period of the previous year.

In US Dollar terms, remittance inflows increased by 24.5 per cent to 4.62 billion in the review period compared to an increase of 13.1 per cent in the same period of the previous year.

In the review period, the number of Nepali workers, both institutional and individual, taking first-time approval for foreign employment stands at 173,555 and taking approval for renewed entry stands at 104,037.

In the previous year, such numbers were 236,779 and 115,948 respectively.

The net transfer increased by 26.3 per cent to Rs. 669.74 billion in the review period, according to the NRB. Such a transfer had increased by 21.6 per cent in the same period of the previous year.

Improvement in both current account and BOP

Meanwhile, there has been further improvement in the current account and Balance of Payment (BOP) during the review period.

The current account remained at a surplus of Rs. 140.23 billion in the review period against a deficit of Rs. 41.21 billion in the same period of the previous year.

In US dollar terms, the current account registered a surplus of 1.05 billion in the review period against a deficit of 322.2 million in the same period last year.

In the review period, capital transfer decreased by 17.2 per cent to Rs. 2.87 billion and net foreign direct investment (FDI) remained positive of Rs.3.92 billion.

In the same period of the previous year, capital transfer amounted to Rs.3.47 billion and net FDI amounted to Rs. 604.9 million.

Similarly, The BOP remained at a surplus of Rs. 210.59 billion in the review period against a surplus of Rs.45.87 billion in the same period of the previous year.

In US Dollar terms, the BOP remained at a surplus of 1.58 billion in the review period against a surplus of 346.8 million in the same period of the previous year, said the NRB.

Inflation moderated to 4.95 %

According to the NRB, the y-o-y consumer price inflation moderated to 4.95 per cent in mid-December 2023 compared to 7.38 per cent a year ago.

Food and beverage category inflation stood at 5.10 per cent whereas non-food and service category inflation stood at 4.84 per cent in the review months.

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PM ASKS BIR HOSPITAL TO PROVIDE FULL TREATMENT



Prime Minister Prachanda

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 11

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has underscored the pivotal role of Bir Hospital as a foundation of the health sector. During discussions with officials from the National Institute of Medical Sciences, he directed them to prioritize patient satisfaction and ensure a complete treatment experience.

In his meeting with the hospital's officials, PM Prachanda emphasised that the nation's health status is reflected in the quality of services provided by Bir Hospital. He expressed the government's commitment to allocating necessary resources to the hospital to enhance its capabilities.

Prachanda urged responsible authorities to deliver high-quality services to patients to ensure a satisfactory treatment. Highlighting the importance of a patient-centric approach over traditional methods he said that the hospital should focus on creating an environment where people can genuinely feel the impact of the services provided for treatment.

PM assured that an expert in the relevant field would be selected in the process of appointment for the position of Chancellor. Dr. Bhupendra Kumar Basnet, the hospital's Vice-Chancellor, highlighted the increased patient load. In response, Prachanda pledged to provide the essential resources required for Bir Hospital to effectively meet the healthcare demands.

COURT ORDERS TO SEND BOMJAN TO JAIL

BY JANARJAN KHATRI
Sarlahi, Jan. 11

The District Court Sarlahi has ordered to send Ram Bahadur Bomjan, the self-proclaimed ascetic, to jail on the charge of child abuse, sexual gratification and disappearance of women.

A bench of the District Court Judge Bishnu Prasad Regmi ordered that 'Ascetic' Bomjan, who was arrested in Kathmandu on Tuesday night, be sent to prison for the preliminary investigation.

Bomjan's statement was collected in Sarlahi District Court on Thursday.

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Law Minister insists on consensus regarding transitional justice bill

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 11

Minister for Law, Justice and Parliamentary Affairs Dhanaraj Gurung has insisted on the need for reaching a consensus on the bill related to transitional justice. Speaking at a meeting of the Law, Justice, and Human Rights Committee of the House of Representatives (HoR) on Thursday, he said there had been an agreement to finalise the bill through consensus whenever feasible.

Gurung added that if consensus was not possible, an alternative procedure would be followed to take the bill to the conclusion. In the meeting chaired by Committee president Bimala Subedi, Nepali Congress Chief Whip Ramesh Lekhak said that it was concerning that survivors of the decade-long armed conflict were deprived of justice when 17 years had already elapsed since the signing of the Comprehensive Peace Accord. "If consensus is not attainable, the bill should be concluded through an established procedure."

CPN (UML) whip Mahesh Bartaula was of the opinion of finalising the bill through a process if consensus remained elusive.

The meeting initiated discussions with a focus on seeking a consensus to advance the bill as much as possible. Simultaneously, considerations were made on following a defined process if a consensus becomes unattainable.

Committee members Santosh Pariyar, Ranju Thakur, Purna Bahadur Gharti, Jeevan Pariyar, Sobita Gautam, Nagina Yadav and Sushila Thing were among those taking part in the discussions.

Kalikot locals take costly trip to obtain salt

BY PREM RAJ SIMKHADA
Kalikot, Jan. 11

Ramane Bohara of Pachaljharana Rural Municipality-6, Kalikot, paid a bus fare of Rs. 1,600 to travel to the salt depot operated by the Salt Trading Corporation (STC) located in the district headquarters Manma. He then paid another Rs. 1,600 to return, meaning the trip cost him at least Rs. 3,200. When in Manma, he spent Rs. 250 on food and snacks.

So, Bohara had to spend a total Rs. 3,450, but all he got was five packets of salt worth Rs. 45. Each packet of salt costs Rs. 9 in five remote districts of Karnali Province due to government subsidy. "We are not asking for gold or silver. All we want is salt for our families. Yet, we are even denied that," he expressed his frustration.

Gauri Sanjyal of Serachaur, Raskot Municipality-1, shared the same frustration. She has to spend Rs. 2,000 to go to and return from Manma. Food and lodging costs an additional Rs. 1,000, meaning she spent Rs. 3,000 for only five packets of salt.



Packs of iodinated salt

STC staff tell her to visit the Raskot depot instead of coming all the way to Manma, but Sanjyal said that the Raskot depot only distributed salt at intervals of three to six months. That too goes mostly too leaders and those with political connections. "Some people get up to five quintals of salt while others get nothing," she said with great indignation.

When Raskot depot distributed salt last month, one ward chairman acquired 50 packets of salt and hid it in a warehouse, several locals told The Rising Nepal.

One day, some youths learnt of the hidden salt and, in anger, took it without telling anyone. The ward chair neither reported this nor took any step to recover the salt. People this paper talked to said that him keeping quiet in this way proves that he had bad intentions.

"If you talk to elected representatives, they will claim that they are doing all they can do get salt for the people, but this is all a lie," Lanka Dhamala of Raskot-8 voiced his displeasure. "What they are actually doing is getting salt for themselves."

Meanwhile, Dambar Bahadur Budha, chief of STC's Manma depot, defended that their salt distribution was in line with the federal government's policies and the District Administration Office's instructions. Instead, he blamed Manma residents for the present problems.

"Whenever we try to devise practical solutions to the distribution issues, we face great opposition from the people here," he said. "This has created difficulties for people who come from far away."

"We understand the people's plight, yet, we are unable to do anything to relieve them," he lamented.

Budha also informed that the quantity of salt allocated for Manma had been decreased. Previously the depot used to get seven quintals of salt every year. "But we do not get that much now. This has also caused problems," he said.

Agriculture should be made main means of business, income generation: Vice President

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 11

Vice President Ramsahay Prasad Yadav has said that agriculture should be made the main means of business and income generation.

Addressing the 'International Policy Dialogue on Neglected and Underutilised Crop Species (Future Smart Crops)' programme organised jointly by the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development and the Food and Agriculture Organisation of the United Nations (FAO) in Kathmandu on Thursday, Vice President Yadav said that although agriculture is the main source of livelihood for most of the people of Nepal, the sector, which covers a quarter of the country's economy, is limited to subsistence farming.

Along with geographical, biological, and cultural diversity, there is also diversity in terms of climate, culture, tradition, food, flora and fauna. Despite this, Nepal's agricultural farming system is limited to some mainstream food crops, he said, according to a statement issued by the Office of the Vice President.

"It is not good that only crops such as rice, corn, wheat, potatoes, etc. appear in the domestic production of the agricultural sector in Nepal, where there is a majority of groups who prefer worshipping nature and celebrating festivals based on food items and other crops. In Nepali food, we mean pulses, rice, and vegetables.



PHOTO: TRN

Vice President Ramsahay Prasad Yadav addressing the 'International Policy Dialogue on Neglected and Underutilised Crop Species (Future Smart Crops)' programme in Kathmandu on Thursday.

It works as a solid food for the manual labourer class, but it is not mandatory to eat these foods to meet the needs of the body. The nutrients obtained from those foods can also be obtained from other foods," he said.

He said other sources of fibrous foods, such as amaranth, buckwheat, millet, etc., are good alternatives to mainstream foods. "However, food items made from millet, barley, etc. are looked down upon and ignored as food for the poor," he said.

The government carries out agricultural commercialisation and food security projects under the name of agricultural development strategy but does not seem to be trying to do anything for the neglected crops, he said, adding, "The Prime Minister Agriculture Modernisation Project is currently underway in the country, in which 177 zones and 16 super zones are in operation. Most of the zones, or super zones, are focused on growing production and productivity of rice, wheat, maize, potatoes, cash crops, and spice crops.

If the concept of sustainable agriculture is not promoted and there is no improvement programme in the case of traditional crops, there will always be a situation of having to import crops that can be easily produced in one's place."

He said that many other neglected species were in Nepal. "The Food and Agriculture Organisation has classified grains, pulses, tubers, vegetable crops, and spice crops with many potentials as 'Future Smart Crops'. It includes Tartary Buckwheat, Sorghum, Proso Millet, Amaranth, Pearl Millet, etc," he said.

"In the current situation, fibrous foods like tartary buckwheat, millet, barley, and yam are considered beneficial even for patients with chronic diseases like heart disease and diabetes. Their demand is increasing in the city," he said.

Rs. 800 M worth of potatoes imported from India through Nepalgunj customs



BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Nepalgunj, Jan. 11

Nepal has been importing potatoes spending billions of rupees every year, despite having huge potential for its production.

The import of potatoes from India through the Nepalgunj border has almost doubled in the first five months of the current fiscal year 2023/24.

Potatoes worth Rs. 800 million were imported from Nepalgunj border only in the five months of the current fiscal year.

During the same period in the last fiscal year 2022/23, potatoes worth only Rs. 450 million were imported.

According to information officer of Nepalgunj Customs Office Dillu Prasad Sharma, about 33,800 tonnes of potatoes worth Rs. 796 million have been imported through this checkpoint during the five months of the current fiscal year.

About 18,200 tonnes of potatoes worth Rs. 457 million were imported from Nepalgunj customs in the first five months of the last fiscal year.

In the last fiscal year, about 37,500 tonnes of potatoes worth Rs. 936 million had been imported from India through this customs office.

The Nepalgunj Customs Office was able to collect revenue of Rs. 197 million only from the import of potatoes in five months of the current fiscal year. It had collected revenue of Rs. 147 million from potato import in the last fiscal year 2022/23.

Private sector welcomes government initiative to solve power tariff arrears

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 11

The private sector has welcomed the initiative taken by the government to solve power tariff arrears in dedicated feeders and trunk lines.

Issuing a press statement, the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FNCCI) and Nepal Chamber of Commerce, welcomed the fact that the government formed a three-member probe committee headed by former judge Girish Chandra Lal on Tuesday to address the disputes of dedicated and trunk lines.

The decision of the government to direct the Nepal Electricity Authority to reconnect the electricity lines of those industries which had been cut immediately is a welcome step, they said.

In order to solve the dispute related to the payment of dedicated and trunk lines, the private sector had been demanding to reconnect the lines immediately and to form a judicial commission to settle the dispute.

The FNCCI appealed to all concerned,



including the government, to ensure the right of the industries to work without interruption by connecting the cut lines immediately.

The industrialists have been saying that they are ready to pay the due amount according to the proof of consumption of dedicated and trunk lines (based on the TOD meter).

As the government as well as the private sector are fully aware of the issues and are ready to solve the problem, the Federation demanded at the beginning that a high-level empowered judicial commission be established to resolve this issue, and as the judicial commission was formed accordingly, it is expected that a long-term solution will be achieved.

The FNCCI said that it is believed that the commission will give an opinion on a fair solution after studying the past context, the current situation, and evidence of electricity consumption, among others.

Similarly, Nepal Chamber of Commerce has said that the government's move to form a judicial committee for a fair solution to the tariff arrears dispute of dedicated and trunk lines is appreciable. The Chamber said that it is confident that the electricity tariff problem will be solved through the formation of a high-level judicial commission.

In a statement issued by NCC, it is said, "During the time of load shedding, there was a difference of opinion between the NEA and industrialists regarding the dedicated and trunk line electricity tariffs to some industries. It was seen that it would affect the overall investment and business-friendly environment.

We are confident that the problem will be solved sooner or later."

The NCC said that the role of both the government and the private sector is equally important for creating an investment- and business-friendly environment.

Gautam Buddha Cricket Stadium to be built with investment of three tiers of government

RSS
Chitwan, Jan 11

The Gautam Buddha Cricket Stadium is to be constructed with joint investment by the three tiers of the government. Dhurmus-Suntali Foundation had initiated the construction of the stadium but abandoned it later. The construction of the stadium has been ensured with the Federal Government giving its approval to the Bharatpur Metropolitan City to construct the structure in partnership with the provincial government.

Bharatpur metropolis mayor Renu Dahal said that a meeting of the Council of Ministers, the Federal Government, on Tuesday gave consent to the metropolis for constructing the 'national pride' project. According to her, the Federal Government will also provide funds in the form of grant for construction of the sports structure.

As per the agreement, the land required for the stadium was to be acquired on land substitution basis, but this provision has been done away with now and the federal government gave approval to acquire land for 40 years in line with the Land Lease Act.

Mayor Dahal said the Bharatpur Metropolitan City is proceeding ahead with the construction of the sports structure after signing land lease agreement with Tribhuvan University and the Agriculture and Forestry University.

The Bagmati provincial government had signed an initial agreement with the metropolis for carrying out the construction works worth Rs 750 million. However, Mayor Dahal said that Rs 1 billion will be required for making the stadium fit for organizing national-level matches as per the metropolis' plan.

According to Dahal, works on constructing the pitch and parapet would be completed in the first phase to make the stadium fit for holding matches.

Giri elected president of REBAN, Sauraha

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 11

Dhruba Giri has been unanimously elected as the president of Restaurant and Bar Association, Nepal (REBAN) Sauraha, a common organisation of restaurant operators in the tourist town of Sauraha, Chitwan.

The 17th Annual General Meeting and the 9th Convention of REBAN, Sauraha elected a new executive committee under the chairmanship of Giri Wednesday.

Shambhu Mali has been elected as the first vice president of the Association, Krishna Bhatta as the second vice president and Rajesh Kumar Tamang as the third vice president.

Similarly, Nabin Nepal has been elected as the general secretary, Kumar Joshi as the secretary, Krishna Prasad Khatiwada as the treasurer and Ambika Bhatta as the co-treasurer of the new executive committee of the Association. Devkala Bhattarai, Purushottam Lamichhane, Dharmaraj Neupane, Ram Kumar Gurau, Ramkaji Adhikari, Sanumaya Thapamgar, Chitra Bahadur Kumal, Ghanashyam Chaudhary, Rajkumar Shrestha and Ishwar Rizal have been selected as members.

Similarly, Roznath Pathak has been selected as the coordinator of the audit committee and Shalikram Rizal and Devilal Shrestha have been selected as members.

On the occasion, REBAN, Sauraha



PHOTO: TRN

Newly elected office-bearers and members of REBAN, Sauraha, pose for a photograph in Chitwan on Wednesday.

has honoured six different personalities including journalist Rajendra Acharya and Bipin Sharma Acharya, who has been actively working in Chitwan for a long time for the promotion of tourism.

Meanwhile, office secretary of the REBAN Sauraha Bhagirath (Gautam) Giri has been felicitated. The Association said that journalists have been honoured by appreciating the unparalleled contribution of fulfilling their professional responsibilities through journalism for the promotion and development of tourism in Sauraha as a place of work. Commitment to overall development of Sauraha

Newly elected President Giri expressed his commitment to moving forward with local, provincial and federal governments along with REBAN and Hotel Association Nepal (HAN) for the overall development of Sauraha. "My special priority will be to establish the indigenous identity of Sauraha and bring tourism to its natural rhythm.

We will also create a new package to extend the stay of tourists in Sauraha by joining hands with businessmen here," he told The Rising Nepal.

Giri said that digital friendly Sauraha will be developed and a campaign will be started to connect Janakpur, Sauraha, Pokhara and Lumbini.

He made it clear that the creation of a culture village that will add attraction to the local Tharu community along with the protection of various tribes will be important during his tenure.

DAIRY FARMERS CALL FOR TIMELY PAYMENT

RSS
Bharatpur, Jan. 11

Dairy farmers have demanded timely payment of milk from the relevant agencies.

Organizing a press conference in Bharatpur on Wednesday, the dairy farmers warned that they would have to leave the dairy business if they do not get their due payment.

They have also put five different demands before the relevant agencies.

The demands include among others concessional loans, addressing the problem of insurance and facilitation of milk production-based subsidies given by the Bagmati provincial government.

On the occasion, President of Chitwan District Milk Producers' Cooperative Association, Kishore Bagaa, lamented that concerned agencies remain apathetic towards solving the problems of dairy farmers in Chitwan.

He also cited problem in the marketing of milk and dairy products.

The problem is getting more complicated due to delay in payment of dairy farmers, who are facing problems in marketing their products.

The dairy sector was moving towards self-sufficiency but the state policy has not been encouraging to the dairy farmers, said the Association Secretary, Kalyan Adhikari.



Yuddha Prasad Mishra: Poet of nature and change

Nandu Uprety



Poet Yuddha Prasad Mishra is one of the top Nepali poets. He is renowned for his naturalistic and transformative poetry. In the first stage of his poetic practice, he wrote some poems influenced by Hindu spiritual thought, but at this time, his poems revealed naturalistic idealism. Senior Nepali critics such as Hrishikesh Upadhyay, Taranath Sharma, Krishnachandra Singh Pradhan, Vasudev Tripathi, Ravilal Adhikari, and Mohanraj Sharma have praised poet Mishra's naturalistic and pure nature poetry. They believe that Mishra has created naturalistic romantic poetry of a level that can be placed in the ranks of the Mahakavi Lakshmi Prasad Devkota and Yugkavi Siddhicharan Shrestha.

Imagination, love of nature, sovereignty in nature, humanisation of nature, feeling of pain and suffering in nature, presentation of peace, liberation and love in nature, national spirit, rebellious voice, and such are few of the qualities of naturalistic romantic poetry expressed in Mishra's poetry. The use of lyricism in poetry is the best feature of Mishra.

Discussing the lyrical style of writing in Nepali Romantic poetry, Taranath Sharma states that this poetic style has danced with Yuddha Prasad and played swing with Lakshmi Prasad Devkota. Similarly, Mohanraj Sharma thinks that Mishra has a unique ability to express nature in a pictorial style.

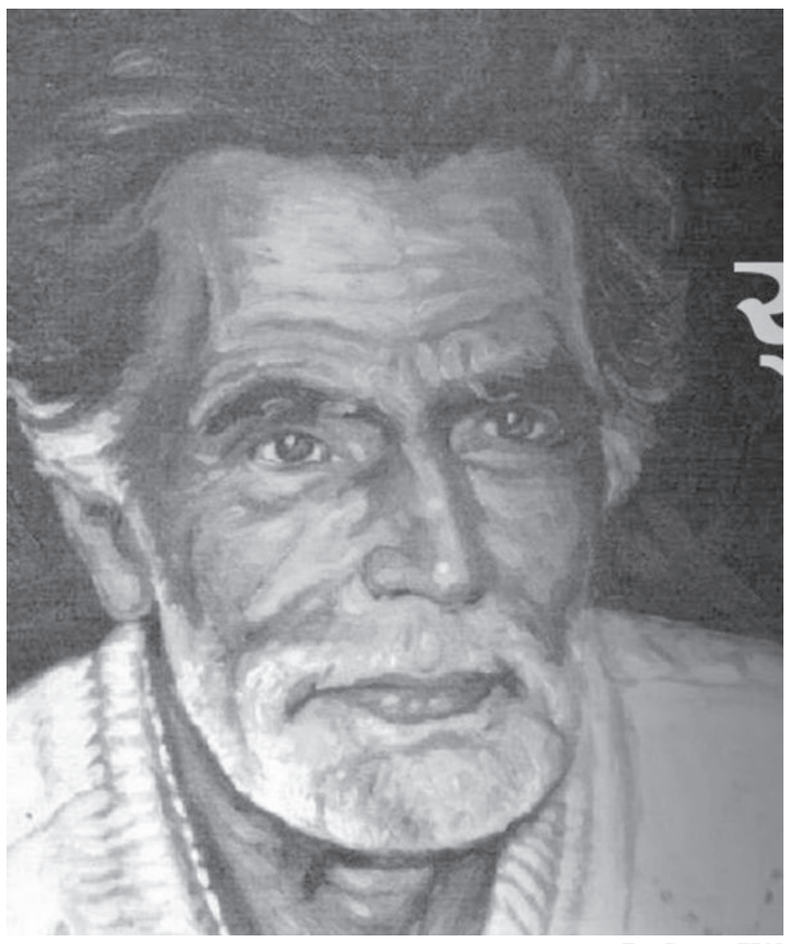
Poet Mishra wrote Charkhandiko khoch, Jabiko chara, Charako bol, Suryaghat, Vyadhgan-1; 2, Hridayapanchhi, Dhobiniko sangit, Simbakkullo, Chariko chchch, Kokil gaan, Pagal-1; 2, Jalan -1; 2; 3; 4, Kavi -1; 2, Sundar kanthi charo and such naturalistic poems. Poet Mishra, who started writing from Hindu spiritual thought, became an excellent poet when he came to create naturalistic poetry.

Mishra saw and experienced the repressive regime of the monarchy, social superstitions, poverty and class discrimination, the underdeveloped state of the country, the miserable life of the people on one side and the beautiful nature, friendly people and a beloved country on the other. Love of nation and people, wonderful desire for freedom and liberation, ardent interest to achieve democracy and republic encouraged him to write poems. As a result, he became a naturalist in poetry writing and gradually became a social realist and moved towards a critical realist stream.

Especially after participating in the anti-Rana movement of B.S. 2004, the door of rebel and social realist poetry seems to have opened. In fact, in 1986 B.S., the short poem 'Ahimsa Prarthana' written by him was burnt by Rana Prime Minister Bhim Shamsher because of anti-Rana sentiments. What this shows is that things like rebellion, irony and humanity were awakened in Mishra's poetic consciousness at an early stage.

The anti-Rana movement and the unsatisfactory situation for the poet after the attainment of democracy seem to have developed a progressive approach in him. While this feeling of his is taking a poetic form, the change of 2017 becomes an important event. After the Panchayat system was implemented, the feeling of anti-Panchayat system becomes stronger in Mishra due to the suffering and hardships in the working life. Not only that, he comes to a conclusion that he cannot live in the country and goes to Banaras, India to spend days of self-exile.

His creative work, which lost momentum for some time, becomes active again due to his contact with the political parties and his closeness with various literary and cultural organizations and persons during his life in self-exile. He continues to create patriotic, awakening, transformative and revolutionary poetry against the autocratic regime in the country.



File Photo: TRN
Poet Yuddha Prasad Mishra.

This time lasted from 2018 to 2040 B.S. Poet Mishra returns home in 2040 from India. After returning home, he gets high esteem as a revolutionary progressive poet. It seems that he is the leader of writers and artists who want to achieve democracy and anticipate a republic system in the country. His poetry became a source of energy for the movement as it was passionate, rebellious and visionary. His poems became the light of the call to establish a new beneficial governance system for the country and the people by demolishing orthodox traditions, superstitions, feudal oppression, tyranny, and misuse of the state power.

Mishra's presence became energetic in the programmes of anti-authoritarian revolutionary writers, poets, and artists organized, especially in Kathmandu and surrounding areas. Equipped with a transformative approach to make people aware from children to the elderly, his poems became songs and started playing as a sharp weapon of the anti-authoritarian movement. Whether it was a programme organized inside a room or in a meeting hall, whether it was an open stage programme, songs like Mishra's volcanoes ignited the flame of passion, vigour, determination and rebellion in the mind of the agitators and changemakers.

Poet Mishra stood at the forefront of the anti-authoritarian movement and led the movement of Nepali poets, writers, and artists. On Chaitra 3, 2046, he came to a programme organized by the revolutionary writers and artists with a black band around his mouth to provide leadership. Mishra was 83 years old at that time. Although his body was old, he had no less passion, no less determination, no less enthusiasm than any youth.

When the police arrested Mishra from the programme, he was saying, "The movement will continue, now change is ahead of us." When the old Mishra, who was carrying a stick with one hand, raised another hand and greeted the poets, writers, and the people present, they showed respect to him with thunderous applause.

Poet Yuddha Prasad Mishra, who created poems that had expectations of Nepali soil, nature, Nepali nation, Nepali people and changes according to time throughout his life, was born on Saturday 27th Paush 1964 B.S. at Somlingtar in Sirutar, Bhaktapur. The natural environment of his village, family situation, friends, social customs, the state of the country, the character of the ruler, etc. were the sources of inspiration for Mishra to practice poetry.

Poet Mishra also wrote some stories during his lifetime. A collection of stories called 'Amar Katha' has been published. In the later part of his life, he also wrote some poems for children. His literary works are 'Ahimsa Prathana' (unpublished) poem: 1986), 'Chara' (Anthology of poetry: 1994), Amar Katha (anthology of short stories: 2015), Muktiramayan (Khandakavya: 2027), Muktasudama (Khandakavya: 2029), Bhadi (Anthology of poetry: 2029), Yuddha Prasad Mishraka Kavitaharu (Anthology of poetry: 2049), School jaau (Child poem: 2057), School janchhu tam tam tam (Child poem: 2063), Vidhyrthi biralo (Child poem: 2063), Hamro bhainsi bubu dinchha (Child poem: 2063), Manamanai ka kha bhanchhu (Child poem: 2064), Aankhai matra tarchhan (Child poem: 2064), Yuddha Prasad Mishraka Kavya Rachanaharu (Anthology of poetry: 2064), Yuddha Prasad Mishraka Pratinidhi Kabitaharu (Anthology of poetry: 2079).

Poet Yuddha Prasad Mishra, who took a lifelong literary lead to prepare the background for political change in Nepal, died on Falgun 6, 2047. No matter how much he contributed to change from his place, the government that took over the country after each change could not remember Mishra's contribution. It is the same situation until today.

Hopefully, this will not happen in the future. The guiding elders will be remembered, and they will be respected. On the occasion of the 117th birth anniversary of Kavi Yuddha Prasad Mishra, we remember and respect him.

(Nandu Uprety is general secretary, Yuddha Prasad Mishra Memorial Foundation.)

Chapakot schools to provide health insurance for parents

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Waling, Jan. 11

Chapakot Municipality in Syangja district has announced a ground-breaking initiative to provide free health insurance to parents who enrol their children in community schools. Mayor Dev Bahadur Khand (Ishwar) revealed that the municipality has introduced the scheme intending to enhance the appeal of the community schools and encourage parents to enrol their wards to community schools.

The health insurance coverage will extend to parents and students whose children are enrolled in community schools across all 10 wards of the municipality. Mayor Khand emphasised his commitment to improving the overall quality of education in general and quality of community schools that runs with the government investment.



Photo: TRN
A school in Chapakot of Waling in Syangja.

The municipality has successfully concluded discussions with employees, stakeholders and peoples representatives to finalise the implementation of this policy, scheduled to take effect in the next municipal meeting. A comprehensive blueprint outlining the procedural details will be prepared to ensure the effective execution of the health insurance programme.

Dhurav Khanal, Chief Administrative Officer of the district, highlighted the municipality's focus on prioritising health insurance for parents residing in economically disadvantaged areas. This programme will be implemented from the upcoming academic session.

In addition to the health insurance initiative, the municipality is actively working on various programmes aimed at enhancing the quality of community schools. These efforts include managing well-equipped physical infrastructure, addressing staff vacancies, and uplifting the overall quality of education.

The municipality oversees 16 community schools, where more than 4,000 students are currently studying. These measures collectively reflect Chapakot Municipality's dedication to fostering a positive and supportive educational environment for its residents.

Report on climate and youth future launched

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 10

Plan International Nepal has launched the report titled "For Our Futures: Youth Voices on Climate Justice and Education" on Wednesday.

The report was jointly launched by Ghana Shyam Aryal, under-secretary at the Ministry of Education, Science and Technology and Deepa Oli, Forest Officer, Department of Forest of Ministry of Forest and Environment.

The report presented the findings of research conducted by youth activists in Nepal, Indonesia and Australia.

The report highlights the effects of climate change on the education of young girls aged between 10 and 24 years. The report is based on a survey of 500 girls and young people.

The researchers have collected 96 photos, graphics or videos from girls and young people impacted by the climate crisis among which 182 respondents and 55 photos were from Nepal.

The launched report "For Our Futures" has highlighted the challenges faced by young people due to climate change and used the moment to amplify the voices of young people to increase support for sustainable climate action.

The key finding of the report is that climate change is preventing girls from realising their right to education. Disruption to education is a unique form of non-economic loss, impacting girls first and foremost.

They are losing school days, with loss of indigenous knowledge, and loss of hope for the future.

The study seeks to understand how climate change has impacted young people's education and what changes young people want to see to protect their right to education.

Central Department of Nepalbhasha launches e-Library



Photo: TRN
Sunita Dangol, Deputy Mayor of KMC, inaugurating e-library, Thursday.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Lalitpur, Jan. 11

Scholars and readers wishing to access books in the collection of the Central Department of Nepalbhasha (CDNB), Tribhuvan University, will now be able to do so online thanks to the e-Library it launched on Thursday.

Available at https://cdnb.edu.np/, the e-Library contains digital versions of the books the Department holds in its physical library at Patandhoka, Lalitpur.

According to the CDNB, the electronic library was developed with financial assistance from the Kathmandu Metropolitan City (KMC) and is accessible to all.

Inaugurating the virtual library, Sunita Dangol, Deputy Mayor of KMC, hoped that it would help expand access to Nepal Bhasa books and research and uplift vernacular academia. "There is no need to come to the library here now.

Researchers and students can read the Department's books from the place and at the time of their convenience," she said.

Dangol also said that the development of the electronic library was the first step that would help KMC and other stakeholders understand what more is needed to develop the Nepal Bhasa language.

Other personalities active in the field of Newa language and culture as well as the Department officials also spoke on the occasion and stressed the need for bringing the library into use and utilising it to preserve and expand Nepal Bhasa knowledge.

Pabitra Bajracharya, chairman of the Newa Dey Daboo, a national forum for Newar organisations of Nepal, and president of the Nepal Retailers' Association, called on the Department to support initiatives to teach Nepal Bhasa.

He said that the library, as well as the adoption of Nepal Bhasa as an official language by the Bagmati Province, would only be relevant if the language was preserved and spoken.

On the occasion, the Department also honoured students who had achieved the highest marks in various years, and also felicitated pupils who received various scholarships.

Among the honourees was Prajit Shakya, a journalist with Gorkhapatra, The Rising Nepal's sister publication.

Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal
Aerodrome Engineering Department
Sinamangal, Kathamndu

Invitation for Bids (IFB)

(First date of Publication 2080/09/27)

Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal (CAAN), Aerodrome Engineering Department (AED) invites electronic bids from all Nepalese eligible bidders for the construction of the following works under National Competitive Bidding procedures. Bids shall be submitted online within 1200 hours NST, 3rd of Falgun, 2080 using the online portal of www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp. Bids shall be opened in the presence of Bidder's representatives who choose to attend at 12:30 hours 3rd of Falgun, 2080 at the office of the Director.

S. N.	Location of the Project	Name of the Work	Contract Identification Number	Procurement Method	Price of Bid Document including VAT (NRs.)	Bid Security Amount Required (NRs.)	Estimated Amount (Including P.S. Excluding VAT & Contingency)
1.	Rukum Salle Airport	Construction of Runway Security Fencing works, at Salle Airport.	CAAN/AED/RUK/ Fencing/080-81/05	NCB: Single Stage Single Envelope	3,390.00	390,000.00	13,589,427.60
2.	Bhojpur Airport	Construction of Outer Chainlink Fencing work at Bhojpur Airport, Bhojpur.	CAAN/AED/BHP/ Fencing/080-81/06	NCB: Single Stage Single Envelope	3,390.00	80,000.00	3,011,104.35
3.	CAA, Sanothimi	Construction of running track, field preparation for various activities and other associated works at CAA.	CAAN/AED/CAA/ R-track/ 080-81/07	NCB: Single Stage Two Envelope	5,650.00	620,000.00	-
4.	CAA, Sanothimi	Different maintenance, gardening & beautification, main gate renovation, fencing, pavement construction and other associated works at CAA, Sanothimi.	CAAN/AED/CAA/ Maintenance/ 080-81/08	NCB: Single Stage Single Envelope	3,390.00	420,000.00	15,082,975.94
5	Sanfebagar Airport	Runway Improvement works at Sanfebagar Airport.	CAAN/AED/ FEB/RWY Slurry/080-81/09	NCB: Single Stage Single Envelope	3390	90,000.00	2,848,972.29

Interested bidders can download the bidding documents from www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp. Bidders are required to follow the electronic bid submission procedure as specified in e-GP system operating Guidelines 2074 and user manuals issued by PPMO related to e-GP system from the website.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

You cannot believe in God until you believe in yourself.
- Swami Vivekananda

EDITORIAL

Hard Time For Herders

Climate change is taking disastrous toll on the farmers in Manang district. Dwindling grazing land has increasingly pushed them out of agriculture and animal husbandry, their traditional occupations. As pasture land shrinks more and more every passing year, so does the number of grazing animals, begetting another grave problem: increasing threat of snow leopards. Unable to find enough prey which once used to be in abundance, snow leopards are increasingly foraying into human settlements in search of food. Feeling endangered by the increasing encounter with the wild beast, natives who have lived there for generations have been leaving what they have called home in droves. Those who had vowed to stay behind until a few years back despite the exodus of their neighbours, are now finding it unbearable to stay on. They are migrating to make new settlements in regions in lower altitudes.

Despite the calendar approaching mid-January, Manang has received minimal amount of snowfall. The absence of snow has hindered the growth of grass, posing a significant threat to the livelihood of farmers in the area. Yak herders like Yangchu Khanda Lama, 60, in the district's Ngisyang Rural Municipality-5 used to store dry grass to feed cattle during the winter. But that is no longer the case, as the dire dearth of water makes it hard for grass to grow. This has added to the challenge to store and reserve dry grass to feed their cattle for another season. Earlier, yak used to graze without herdsmen in pasture. But nowadays, the farmers complain that the fear of snow leopards has made it impossible to be a herder.

Warming climate means glacial melt has accelerated in the Himalayas. Land once used for growing crops has turned barren. As temperature has risen, mosquitoes carrying diseases like malaria and dengue have started making their presence in the upper region where until recently that was unheard of. Climate scientists have warned that even if the world's most ambitious climate change goal was met, one-third of the Himalayan glaciers would melt by 2100. Climate change is remaking the Himalayan region, putting millions of people who depend on its water resources at risk and driving mountain dwellers from their homes.

In a country where a bulk of its population rely on agriculture for survival as well as livelihood, reduced water supply can shrink food production, which in turn can lead to rise in food prices. And food prices climbing to unaffordable levels is a recipe for instability and widespread violence, which we have seen in several countries. What's more, it also risks reversing the hard-earned gains in poverty alleviation and development. There is another danger: rapidly melting glaciers giving rise to glacial lakes, which threaten settlements and infrastructure downstream as the meltwater continuing to feed them will eventually lead to their bursts.

The glimpses of warmer future are everywhere, and so are its impacts. In the face of imminent perils that can bring even more devastation, we have no option but to adapt. Climate migrants must be the number one priority. The government should consider granting legal rights to the new land such migrants are now living in, having been driven out of their ancestral land. And those who have to abandon their traditional livelihood deserve to be given new means to make a living. This is where the green climate fund, particularly the one meant to redress the climate impacted loss and damage, should be used.

In Guise Of Spirituality

BINI DAHAL

Even when modernity along with artificial intelligence has taken over the world, spirituality and spiritual gurus remain a matter of great interest for many. While becoming spiritually inclined is a good thing, what is more concerning is the rising number of fake spiritual leaders and preachers around us. There are people who consider themselves to be an incarnation of god and have created a lot of fan following through their gimmicks blindly.

When rumours spread about how a certain individual is a god, it piques the interest of many. A question arises as to how an individual living around a bunch of normal people has turned into a god. And what exactly is the individuals' power and ability that justifies them being considered the almighty? But these aspects are rarely pondered upon rationally. This is why innocent people become an easy prey to such forged persons.

Recently, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CIB) of Nepal Police got hold of Ram Bahadur Bomjan after four long years of investigation. Dubbed as Little Buddha, Bomjan came into limelight around 2005 when he claimed he could meditate for months without food, water and sleep. After that he went on to establish his own ashram. He gained a wider popularity at home and abroad. But he was and has never been away from controversies. As someone who always preaches non-violence, he was found attacking innocent people living close to his ashram. Not just this, over the years, he has been blamed for a number of other crimes. He is accused of raping underage girls, sexually exploiting women and causing people to disappear from his ashram. As of now, three girls are reported to have gone missing from his spiritual site. It is also reported that under his instructions a woman had been beaten to death in his ashram itself.

When the police finally got hold of Bomjan, he was found living with his family in Budhanilkantha. The police then raided his home and confiscated more than Rs. 33 million in cash from his residence. This amount combines both Nepali and foreign currency. The CIB also found him owning several expensive vehicles which included cars, motorcycles and a scooter. He apparently had made a down payment to a showroom to purchase an expensive car as well. As the police investigates further, there still remains a large group of followers who do not believe the accusations labelled on the man. Further investigations are expected to reveal more mysteries about this 'spiritual guru.'

We live in a capitalistic society. And nearly every action is linked in some way or other to earning or collecting money. By manipulating innocent people, such charlatans claim that they know everything. Thus, they are running their business. However, for some, it is not just money. They feel they have the right and the ability to control and exploit people, especially those who are weak.

Today's fast-paced lives come with stress and suffering. Especially for those who are adulting, they are bound to be mentally burdened with every day responsibilities. In a situation as such, yoga and meditation can work wonders. And for many trying to get closer to God, especially for old-age people, it feels great and peaceful.

But we cannot stress enough that in the name of spirituality and religion, innocent people are being used and exploited. It is high time the authorities played an important role in putting a full stop to fake activities.

Soft-Power Diplomacy An Urgent Need

Dr. Narad Bharadwaj



Foreign relation is a vast field of statecraft with equally large assortment of policy tools to further diplomatic functions. Soft power diplomacy, which was first coined and popularised by Joseph Nye in 1990s, is one of such tools which has gained currency in modern diplomatic discourse. According to him soft power diplomacy is an ability to affect others to obtain the outcome one wants through attraction rather than coercion. Foreign policy is understood as an extension of domestic policy. In line with this understanding, countries aspiring to achieve economic prosperity and a respectable pedestal in the community of nations, attach as much importance to foreign policy issues as they accord priority to domestic affairs. Every country, big or small, has its foreign policy priorities which are always aligned with national goals. The governments of these countries make use of proper policy tools to get international attention to their priorities.

Leverage

Rich countries with military might have multiple options in their diplomatic tool box. The rich countries try to subjugate weak countries through the use of grants, assistance or investment in mega projects. If this does not work, they do not hesitate to play hard ball diplomacy to extract what they want. But the luxury of choice is limited for weaker and smaller countries. They can only use soft power diplomacy to gain international visibility, win empathy, forge common stand on international issues and attract development partnership. Like many developing countries of the world, Nepal is endowed with some rich resources and historical advantage of being one of the oldest countries of South Asia which it can use as its soft power to further international diplomacy. These resources can be used as a leverage to enhance Nepal's international influence, shape the perception of foreign countries towards us and attract them to engage with us and become our development partners.

In Nepal's context, soft power diplomacy is often equated with economic diplomacy. But in reality, it covers far wider areas of engagement. It is rooted in self-sustainability of economic resources and projection of value systems represented by culture, education, tourism, religion and a host of other factors including geo-political location which come into play in dealing with international community for serving national interest. In a complex geo-political context of the region, moving pieces in the diplomatic chessboard is not easy for a country like Nepal. Surrounded as we are by two giant adversarial neighbours with incompatible expectations from us, we cannot afford to make single wrong move nor can we stay stuck in stalemate. The best course for us is to navigate our pieces through the traps and temptations towards a win-win situation.

For this we need to groom a corps of competent, knowledgeable, communicative and academically sound diplomats who are patriotic, conversant in international languages and well aware of their countries potentials to be tapped by mobilising domestic and external resources or gaps to be bridged through capacity enhancement. Our diplomats should be sharp-eyed to detect emerging geo-political dynamics and help the concerned stakeholders to prioritise and suggest proactive actions to resolve polemical issues of international politics. Diplomats deputed in foreign countries should be media savvy and well connected to strategic leaders of the host countries and the diplomatic community at large. A diplomat's job is to be always on the look out of unfolding events and to be quick to use relevant forums to amplify the voice of the nation.

> Soft power diplomacy represents a vast array of possibilities for Nepal in building relation, overcoming barriers, promoting dialogue, shaping perceptions towards us.

In recent years, small countries like Qatar and Singapore have enhanced their stature in international politics by enhancing their convening capacity for resolving international disputes. The successful mediation of Qatar in securing release and repatriation of abducted Ukrainian children from Russia and its tough negotiation with Israel and Hamas for freeing Israeli hostages has provided it a high perch disproportionate to its size. It shows that peace deal can be clinched even through seemingly intractable situation if a neutral country with nuanced understanding of the geopolitical intricacies and credible diplomatic record comes forward to take risk.

As discussed above, the existence of a core group of qualified diplomats in foreign missions and a far-sighted political leadership capable of mobilising them is the most strategic and cream component of soft power diplomacy. But there always are other national assets which can be processed, enriched and showcased to attract foreign investors, development partners, visitors and admirers, helping put the country's core competence on international spotlight. Nepal is a country which has fairly large tracts of fertile agricultural land and is endowed with diverse climate zones appropriate for production of diverse food crops, fruits and vegetables. Abundant availability of perennial running water makes agricultural prospects alluring. At a time when global hunger stares hard in the face of humanity, we have every possibility of showcasing our agricultural sector as our soft power.

Overseas employment

About 4 million Nepali youths are working in overseas employment markets around the world. The remittances we receive from them are sustaining our national economy. These youths are priceless soft power of Nepal. We could change the entire perspective of how the world views at Nepal's work force if we could provide them opportunity to enhance their technical skills and language efficiency required at the workplace of the host countries.

Similarly, the Himalayan mountains peaks, rivers, lakes, beautiful landscapes together with pristine trekking routes can attract hundreds of thousands of expeditioners, adventurers, trekkers, artists and litterateurs from around the world. Similarly, our cultures, bio-diversity, the aura of mysticism surrounding our temples, mosques, monasteries, old palaces, rites, rituals and ceremonies are all the soft powers of Nepal which can help establish Nepal's unique identity in the global society.

In conclusion, soft power diplomacy represents a vast array of possibilities for Nepal in building relation, overcoming barriers, promoting dialogue, shaping perceptions towards us and help garner support by winning empathy from the international community. This is a tool, which, if used properly, will transform Nepal into a prosperous, peaceful and democratic country with an enviable position in the community of nations.

Dr. Bharadwaj is former ambassador and former chairperson of Gorkhapatra Corporation. bharadwajnarad@gmail.com

Remembering The Nation's Unifier

Buddhi Narayan Shrestha



When we look at the historical background of the boundary of Nepal, Prithvi Narayan Shah had initiated a campaign to unify small kingdoms and principalities of the Himalayan region in 1744 AD. After the annexing of the Kathmandu Valley, he unified other smaller kingships south of the valley to keep out the influence and control of the British rule. After his kingdom spread out from north to south, he made Kantipur the capital of the expanded country, and called it 'Nepal' instead of 'Gorkha'. As a result, Prithvi Narayan Shah formally established Nepal as a Himalayan nation and thus, Nepal was born on 16 November 1769.

If Shah had not started to unify various principalities of the Himalayan region, it would have been fallen into the British domination. So, we have to remember Shah's contribution that formed a single nation Nepal. Before his death, he had expressed his *Upadesh* or thoughts of wisdom that are still relevant in the context of economic activities, security, diplomacy and protection of the boundaries.

Diplomatic vision

Last year, President Bidya Devi Bhandari's greeting message given on the occasion of Prithvi Jayanti and National Unity Day on January 11 stated, 'The thought given by Prithvi Narayan Shah at that time is equally relevant in the current context.' On the occasion, she placed flowers and garlands on the statue in front of the main gate of Singha Durbar. As a remembrance of his unification work, the government had given a public holiday on January11 last year across Nepal and to Nepali embassies and diplomatic missions abroad. It has been decided to give a holiday this year as well.

If we talk about Prithvi Narayan's vision, his diplomatic essence was that Nepal should be protected from the interference of both the northern and southern neighbours. He said, 'Nepal is like a yam between two boulders. Keep friendship with the Emperor of China. At the same time, it is necessary to make a strong friendship also with the Emperor of the South. But he is very clever. He is occupying Hindustan and he is eyeing the plain area of Nepal also.'

It is a vital motto of diplomacy for Nepal that if it inclines to one neighbour, there is a possibility that it may harm Nepal. Nepal has to walk on a razor's edge. If Nepal slips from the razor edge to the south, it will come under its umbrella. If it is slipped to the north, Nepal will be influenced by their ideology.

Four years ago, our southern neighbor published the 'Political Map of India' and included 372 square kilometres of area of Limpiyadhura-Kalapani-Lipulek region within their territory, which is the sovereign land of Nepal. Nepal responded and called for talks. But India was not ready.

> The manner in which he described Nepal as a 'yam between two boulders' and the balanced relationship between the neighbors is still admirable today.

Therefore, Nepal published the *Chuche Naksa* three years ago.

China published a new map on August 11, 2023. But it did not depict the *Chuche Naksa* of Lipulek-Kalapani-Limpiyadhura region of Nepal. It is due to the fact that Nepal did not send the *Chuche Naksa* to China, nor to India and the United Nations. Had the vision of Prithvi Narayan been executed, China would have incorporated Nepal's *Chuche Naksa* to its new map.

PN Shah had expressed his vision that 'Prepare forts on the boundaries on both northern and southern sides. Construct seven strong forts around *Chaar Bhanjyang* (Kathmandu Valley) in Shivapuri, Phulchoki, Chandragiri, Mahadevpokhari, Palung, Dapcha, and Kahule Bhanjyang.'

'Install cannons in a ready position in a row in all forts. Build iron gates in all crossings and keep a cannon in each gate in a ready condition and depute five soldiers each over there. If we could do so, any person involved in watching our activities, talking against us, thinking of committing crime and causing damage to anyone, spying on the people and the criminals will also be unable to do any harm. And even all the Four Emperors do attacked us, they would be defeated.' If we make such strategies, they will easily be defeated at the crossings of the Chure hills. If we could do so, we will be able to extend our boundaries up to the Sriganga River,' the great unifier said.

Relevance

Prithvi Narayan Shah's thoughts, sayings, or ideas are the foundation of Nepali nationalism and the soul of the nation. Even at the present time when political leaders lack a sense of stability and a balance of power, they must remember Prithvi Narayan's vision of unification. If the scattered ideas of the current political leaders are unified, the graph of overall prosperity of Nepal would go up.

The main crux is that whatever vision Prithvi Narayan Shah had at that time, is equally relevant even today, after three centuries. The manner in which he described Nepal as a 'yam between two boulders' and the balanced relationship between the neighbors is still admirable today. Therefore, in the current situation, it is appropriate to look at Prithvi Narayan Shah from a historical point of view. He deserves honour him as he unified the small kingdoms into a strong nation. On the basis of his contribution to the nation, it is relevant to remember him in order to develop Nepal further and protect nationality, sovereignty and territorial integrity.

(The author is an expert on border issues.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 12, 1974

Nepal Bank Deposits Double In 3 Years

Kathmandu, Jan 11: The current, saving and fixed deposits of Nepal Bank Limited has more than double in the last three years, reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Address Yak Herders Concerns

This is in reference to a news report, *"Lack of pasture land hits yak herders in Manang"* published on Jan.11 in your prestigious daily. According to the news report, a lack of grazing land has caused locals in Manang to move away from their traditional occupations of agriculture and animal husbandry.

A shortage of grass and a growing fear of snow leopards have posed a challenge for the locals. This has caused a growing aversion towards farming, pushing people to look for alternative jobs.

The effect of climate change is also evident in the shortage of water, low availability of grass, among others. As people used to store dry grasses before, this is no longer possible, and they are also unable to store grasses for the next season.

The rising number of snow leopards has made it hard for the herders to take their animals out of fear that they will get eaten.

Amidst these challenges, the local authorities should work together with



the local people to ensure that they have a source of income. Also necessary actions should be taken to ensure that agriculture and livestock farming remains an important part of the locals.

Dikshya Karki
New Baneshwor, Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

The football coach walked into the locker room before a game, looked over to his star player and said, "I'm not supposed to let you play since you failed math, but we need you in there. So, what I have to do is ask you a math question, and if you get it right, you can play."

The player agreed, and the coach looked into his eyes intently and asks, "Okay, now concentrate hard and tell me the answer to this. What is two plus two?"

The player thought for a moment and then he answered, "4?"

"Did you say 4?" the coach exclaimed, excited that he got it right.

At that, all the other players on the team began screaming, "Come on coach, give him another chance!"

Israel faces Gaza genocide charges

AFP
The Hague, Jan. 11

South Africa on Thursday accused Israel of breaching the UN Genocide Convention, saying that even the October 7 Hamas attack could not justify such alleged actions.

Pretoria has lodged an urgent appeal to the International Court of Justice (ICJ) to force Israel to "immediately suspend" its military operations in Gaza. Israel has dismissed the case as "atrocious" and "preposterous".

"No armed attack on a state territory no matter how serious... can provide justification for or defend breaches of the convention," said Pretoria's Justice Minister Ronald Lamola.

"Israel's response to the Oct. 7 attack has crossed this line and given rise to the breaches of the convention," he added, setting out South Africa's case at the ICJ.

The war in Gaza erupted when Hamas launched its unprecedented October 7 attack, which resulted in about 1,140 people killed in Israel, mostly civilians, according to an AFP tally based on official figures.

Israel has responded with a relentless military campaign that has killed at least 23,357 people, mostly women and children, according to the Hamas-run Gaza health ministry.

South Africa argues Israel is breaking its commitments under the UN Genocide Convention, a treaty signed in 1948 as the world cried "never again" after the Holocaust.

As a fellow signatory to the treaty, South Africa can take Israel to the ICJ, which rules on disputes between countries and is often described as the "World Court".

The ruling African National Congress (ANC) has long been a firm supporter of the Palestinian cause, often linking it to its own struggle against the white-minority government, which had cooperative relations with Israel.

South Africa has acknowledged the "particular weight of responsibility" of accusing Israel of genocide and "unequivocally" condemned the Hamas attacks that touched off the war in Gaza.

Israel will present its own arguments on Friday but President Isaac Herzog has already hinted at his country's likely defence.

"There's nothing more atrocious and preposterous than this claim," said Herzog.

"We will be in the International Court of Justice and we will present proudly our case of using self defence... under international humanitarian law," he said.

He said the Israeli army was "doing its utmost under extremely complicated circumstances on the ground to make sure that there will be no unintended consequences and no civilian casualties."



PHOTO: AFP

A protester holds a Palestinian flag during a demonstration outside the International Court of Justice (ICJ) in The Hague, Netherlands on January 11, 2024.

ICJ HEARINGS OPEN

The United States is backing its ally Israel, with the State Department describing the charges as "unfounded."

"In fact, it is those who are violently attacking Israel who continue to openly call for the annihilation of Israel and the mass murder of Jews," said State Department spokesman Matthew Miller.

As it is an urgent procedure, the ICJ could rule in a matter of weeks.

Its rulings are final and cannot be appealed. However, countries do not always follow the court's verdicts—the ICJ has ordered Russia to stop its invasion of Ukraine for example.

But a court ruling against Israel will certainly increase political pressure on the country, with many speculating it could serve as a pretext for sanctions.

Cecily Rose, assistant professor of public international law at Leiden University, said the court does not have to rule on the fundamentals of the case at this stage—that issue will likely take years.

"Instead, the court would only be evaluating whether there is a risk of irreparable prejudice to rights held under the Genocide Convention, in particular the right of the Palestinians in Gaza to be protected from acts that threaten their existence as a group," Rose told AFP.

As 15 people were killed, emergency declared in Papua New Guinea

AGENCIES
Papua New Guinea, Jan.11

More than 1,000 troops are on standby "to step in wherever necessary", Prime Minister James Marape said on Thursday. Shops and cars were torched and supermarkets looted after police went on strike on Wednesday over a pay cut the authorities say was a mistake.

The unrest follows wider tensions in the Pacific Island nation over rising costs and high unemployment. "Breaking the law does not achieve certain outcomes," Mr Marape said in a national address. He announced the state of emergency in Port Moresby would last for 14 days.

While most of the violence had been curbed by Wednesday evening, after soldiers were deployed and police resumed duty, the prime minister acknowledged that the situation was "still tense".

The Port Moresby General Hospital confirmed eight deaths in the capital, while another seven people were reported to have died in the city of Lae, PNG's second largest. The absence of police encouraged people from the capital's outskirts to ransack shops and cause wider destruction, locals told.

"We have seen unprecedented level of strife in our city, something that has never happened before in the history of our city and our country," National Capital District Governor Powes Parkop said in a radio address on Wednesday, according to a Reuters news agency report.

He said the looting had largely been carried out by "opportunists". Some violence was also reported to have been carried out by police demonstrators.

> The unrest follows wider tensions in the Pacific Island nation over rising costs and high unemployment. "Breaking the law does not achieve certain outcomes," Mr Marape said in a national address.

People run with merchandise as crowds leave shops with looted goods amid a state of unrest in Port Moresby on January 10, 2024. Shops and cars were set on fire and supermarkets looted across the city. The unrest was triggered after police and other public servants staged a protest strike outside parliament on Wednesday, after discovering that their wages had been reduced by up to 50% in their latest pay cheques.

In response, Mr Marape said the pay cut was an error due to a computer glitch - which had deducted up to $100 (£78) from the pay cheques of public servants. He said the administrative error would be corrected in next month's payments. But this answer was not accepted by many protesters, some of whom then tried to push into the parliament building - with footage showing people torching a car outside the prime minister's compound and overrunning a gate.

Christie ends his presidential bid

AP
Windham, N.H., Jan. 11

Former New Jersey Gov. Chris Christie on Wednesday suspended his Republican presidential bid just days before Iowa's leadoff caucuses, ceding to growing pressure to drop out of the race from those desperate to deny Donald Trump a glidepath to the nomination.

Addressing supporters at a New Hampshire town hall, Christie said he had come to the conclusion that he had no pathway to victory.

"Campaigns are run to win. That's why we do them," he said. "It's clear to me tonight that there isn't a path for me to win the nomination."

"My goal has never been to be just a voice against the hate and division and the selfishness of what our party has become under Donald Trump," he added, vowing to continue to warn the party and the country about the dangers of a second Trump term.

"I am going to make sure that in no way do I enable Donald Trump to ever be president of the United States again. And that's more important than my own personal ambition," he said.

Christie did not immediately endorse any of rivals and instead continued to lace into them in his remarks for failing to directly target Trump for fear of alienating the front-runner's loyal supporters. Underscoring his deep frustrations, he was overheard on a hot mic before the event began criticizing former United Nations Ambassador Nikki Haley.



PHOTO: AP

Republican presidential candidate former New Jersey Gov. Chris Christie announces he is dropping out of the race during a town hall campaign event Wednesday, Jan. 10, 2024, in Windham, N.H.

Zelenskyy rules out cease-fire with Russia

AP
Tallinn, Estonia, Jan. 11

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy on Thursday ruled out a cease-fire in his country's war with Russia, saying the Kremlin's forces would use the pause to rearm and regroup before overwhelming Kyiv's troops.

"A pause on the Ukrainian battlefield will not mean a pause in the war," Zelenskyy said during a visit to Estonia.

"A pause would play into (Russia's) hands," he said. "It might crush us afterward."

Limited cease-fires have occasionally been proposed since Russia's full-scale invasion in February 2022 but have never taken hold.

Both sides are scrambling to replenish their weapons after 22 months of fighting and with the prospect of a protracted conflict. With the roughly 1,500-kilometre (630-mile) front line mostly static during freezing winter weather, they both require artillery shells, missiles and drones that enable long-range strikes.

Zelenskyy noted that Moscow is allegedly buying artillery shells and missiles from North Korea and drones from Iran.

Zelenskyy was in the Estonian capital Tallinn as part of a two-day swing through Baltic countries which have been among Ukraine's staunchest supporters in the war.

The Ukrainian president is pressing allies to provide his country with more support, after already receiving billions of dollars in military aid from its Western allies.

"Ukraine needs more, it needs better weapons," Estonian President Alar Karis said during a joint news conference with Zelenskyy at the Presidential Palace.

Karis noted that European Union countries have so far provided 85 billion euros ($93 billion) of support for Ukraine.

But the flow of support has slowed, alarming Ukrainians who would find it hard to stand alone against their bigger neighbour.



PHOTO: AP

Estonia's President Alar Karis, left, welcomes Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, in Tallinn, Estonia, Thursday, Jan. 11, 2024.

PRISM

University aims to revive words

Michigan: Michigan's Wayne State University released its 15th annual list of "long-lost" words due for a comeback, including blatherskite, rawgabbits, dollop and petrichor.

Wayne State's "Word Warriors program," which "aims to resurrect long-lost -- but not completely forgotten -- words" is compiled from suggestions by website administrators and members of the public.

This year's words include blatherskite, a person who talks at great length without making much sense; curglaff, the shock felt when one first plunges into cold water; dollop, a shapeless mass or blob of something; kaffeeklatsch, an informal social gathering at which coffee is served; and pawky, having a mocking or cynical sense of humour.

"Once again, our Word Warriors have provided a collection of words that makes our language a bit livelier," Chris Williams, head of the Word Warriors program and assistant director of editorial services for Wayne State Marketing and Communications, said in a news release.

Deer rescued from frozen pond

New Hampshire: Police and fire-fighters in New Hampshire came to the rescue of a deer found stranded on the ice in the middle of a large pond.

The Pelham Police Department said officers responded Tuesday morning to a report of a deer stranded on the ice covering Harris Pond.

"We requested the assistance of the Pelham Fire Department to assist in rescuing the deer," the department said in a Facebook post.

Photos from the scene show rescuers using an inflatable raft to venture out onto the ice and frigid waters to reach the stranded animal.

(Agencies)

British postal scandal ruined hundreds of lives

AP
London, Jan. 11

British Prime Minister Rishi Sunak has said he will introduce measures to reverse the convictions of more than 900 Post Office branch managers wrongly accused of theft or fraud because of a faulty computer system in what is considered one of the gravest injustices in the nation's history.

The announcement Wednesday follows a TV docudrama on the wrongdoing that created a huge surge of public support for the former postmasters who have spent years trying to reclaim lives ruined by the scandal.

"This is one of the greatest miscarriages of justice in our nation's history," Sunak said. "People who worked hard to serve their communities had their lives and their reputations destroyed through absolutely no fault of their own. The victims must get justice and compensation."

Lawmakers said they would provide compensation to those who had been convicted. Some also called for bringing those to justice who were responsible for the wrongdoing.

After the Post Office rolled out the Horizon IT system, developed by Japanese company Fujitsu, in 1999 to automate sales accounting, local Post Office managers began finding unexplained losses they were responsible to cover.

The state-owned Post Office maintained Horizon was reliable and accused branch managers of dishonesty. Between 2000 and 2014, some 900 postal workers were wrongly accused of theft, fraud and false accounting, with some convicted and imprisoned and others forced into bankruptcy.

In total, over 2,000 people were affected by the scandal. Some committed suicide or attempted it. Others said their marriages fell apart and reported becoming community pariahs.

A group of postal workers took legal action against the Post Office in 2016. Three years later the High Court in London ruled that Horizon contained a number of "bugs, errors and defects" and that the Post Office "knew there were serious issues about the reliability" of the system.

"Failures of investigation and disclosure were so egregious as to make the prosecution of any of the 'Horizon cases' an affront to the conscience of the court," Justice Timothy Holroyde said.



PHOTO: AP

A logo of post office is displayed in London, Wednesday, Jan. 10, 2024.

To date, just 95 convictions have been overturned, Post Office minister Kevin Hollinrake said.

A government minister claimed this moment of reckoning has long been coming. But it was turbo-charged by a four-part TV docudrama that aired Jan. 1 and fuelled public outrage that led to days of bruising headlines about the scandal and sparked a swift response by lawmakers.

The ITV show, "Mr. Bates vs the Post Office," told the story of branch manager Alan Bates, played by Toby Jones, who has spent nearly two decades trying to expose the scandal and exonerate his peers.

Despite hundreds of news stories over the years about court hearings and an ongoing public inquiry, the show seen by millions rapidly galvanized support for victims of the injustice.

Police last week opened a fraud investigation into potential offenses of perjury and perverting the course of justice over investigations and prosecutions carried out by the Post Office.

More than a million people signed an online petition calling for former Post Office chief executive Paula Vennells to lose her Commander of the Order of the British Empire title she received in 2018. By the end of Tuesday, she said she would relinquish the honour.

The Post Office is state owned with independent franchise operators. Branch owners and employees typically lived in the communities where they operated and many became outcasts when accused of stealing.

TODAY IN HISTORY

475 – Byzantine Emperor Zeno is forced to flee his capital at Constantinople, and his general, Basiliscus gains control of the empire.

1528 – Gustav I of Sweden is crowned King of Sweden, having already reigned since his election in June 1523.

1554 – Bayinnaung, who would go on to assemble the largest empire in the history of Southeast Asia, is crowned King of Burma.

1848 – The Palermo rising takes place in Sicily against the Bourbon Kingdom of the Two Sicilies.

1866 – The Royal Aeronautical Society is formed in London.

1872– Yohannes IV is crowned Emperor of Ethiopia in Axum, the first imperial coronation in that city in over 200 years.



PHOTO: RSS

Devotees in large number gather on banks of Betrawati River between Rasuwa and Nuwakot districts to pay homage and make offerings to their deceased ancestors on the occasion of dark moon day in the month of Poush.

Lekhak rules out vote crossing in NA poll

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 11

Coordinator of the National Assembly Election Coordination Committee of the ruling coalition parties Ramesh Lekhak has said that no votes from the ruling parties would be cast out of the ruling coalition candidates.

Lekhak, who is also Chief Whip of the Nepali Congress, said the situation of dividing votes and casting them to the candidates out of the ruling coalition candidates would not be invited because of limited voters in the NA poll.

Talking with journalists on the Parliament Secretariat premises in Singha Durbar on Thursday, leader Lekhak said that Provincial Assembly members, local-level chiefs and deputy chiefs are the voters, they represent the parties and are well aware of the contemporary political situation and would cast votes accordingly.

He informed the plan of the ruling coalition that it would introduce candidates to the voters as one party's voters do not know the candidates of another party.

The task will be held by the ruling coalition's central, provincial and district coordination committees, he said.

The Central Coordination Committee started its job on Wednesday by forming provincial committees and district committees.

Lekhak informed his committee would fully play a role in securing the victory for the ruling coalition candidates in the election to the National Assembly member that is slated for January 25.

He said his committee would do its best to manage the NA election properly.

Shraddha rituals performed

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 11

Thousands of people thronged the religious sites of Gokarna in the Kathmandu Valley, Barahachhetra and Bishnupaduka Temple in Sunsari and Uttargaya at Betrawati in Rasuwa district to perform Shraddha on the occasion of Poush Krishna Aunshi on Thursday.

The relatives of deceased families gathered at Kokaha and Bishnupaduka of Barahachhetra on the day of Poush Krishna Aunshi to perform the Shraddha as per the Vaidik rituals, according to our Sunsari correspondent.

Thousands of Hindu devotees gathered on the bank of the Kokaha Kaushiki River to perform the rituals in the name of the deceased parents and grandparents, said Raju Ghimire, secretary of Barahachhetra Conservation Forum.

The three-day festival began on Wednesday at the Barahachettra Temple and the Kokaha Kaushiki River and it will run till Friday. People from several parts of Nepal, Bihar of India, Bhutan and Sikkim have arrived in Barahachhetra to perform Shraddha.

Likewise, many people in Kathmandu reached Gokarna in Kathmandu and Betrawati in Rasuwa to perform the Shraddha on Thursday.

NEPALI ENVOY PRESENTS CREDENCE IN SWITZERLAND

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 11

Nepal's ambassador to Switzerland Ram Prasad Subedi presented the Letters of Credence to Viola Amherd, President of the Swiss Confederation amidst a special ceremony organised at the Federal Palace in Bern, Switzerland on January 9.

Upon arrival at the Palace, the Ambassador was accorded Guard of Honour.

Issuing a press statement, the Embassy of Nepal in Geneva of Switzerland, informed that Ambassador Subedi conveyed greetings and best wishes from President Ramchandra Paudel and Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' to the Swiss President's health and happiness as well as for the continued peace, progress and prosperity of the people of Switzerland.

Ambassador Subedi also expressed his commitment to working towards further strengthening bilateral ties and expanding the areas of cooperation. He further elaborated on the opportunities to work together in the areas of trade, tourism and investment, the statement read. He also acknowledged the Swiss support through Swiss Development Cooperation in Nepal, including in the peace process.

'Seeking permission can prevent child marriage'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 11

Minister for Women, Children and Senior Citizens Surendra Raj Acharya has said that there should be a provision for obtaining marriage permission to prevent child marriage practices in Nepal.

Speaking at the concluding ceremony of a campaign launched to prevent child marriage practices in Nepal organised by the World Vision International Nepal (WVI) and Rural Women's Development and Unity Centre (RUWDUC) on Thursday, Minister Acharya said that child marriage could be stopped if there was a provision to get marriage permission from the concerned ward office before one ties the nuptial knot.

Stating that Nepal has set a target to end child marriage by 2030, Minister Acharya said that steps should now be taken from the ward level as no desired results were a chieved in controlling the evil practice despite making policy arrangements.

Minister Acharya said, "Child marriage is a criminal act and it robs children of their rights. Grassroots level awareness is key to stopping child marriage in the communities, at the same time a common effort of all stakeholders is required to end child marriage from our community".

Dr. Arzu Rana Deuba, Member of Parliament, expressing her commitment to continue to work on the issue relating to children, specifically on girls and women, said that social awareness was not enough to end child marriage as targeted by the government.

"Implementation of policies is also key to ending child marriage," she said.



Organised in collaboration with the government and various Civil Society Organisations, the event was attended by child rights experts and stakeholders and included a session on national-level policy dialogue discussing the roles and responsibilities of the government, civil society organisations, national and international NGOs to eliminate child marriage from Nepal by 2030.

The government has a target to end child marriage as outlined in the National Strategy on Ending Child Marriage 2016, aligning with the Sustainable Development Goals.

Over the past six years, the campaign has reached over 400,000 children and successfully collaborated with different levels of government in six provinces, formulating 44 policies related to ending child marriage.

The campaign 'It Takes Nepal to End Child Marriage' began in Nepal in August 2017 through a formal launch by the then President Bidya Devi Bhandari.

Speaking at the concluding ceremony, Roslyn H. Gabriel, the National Director of WVI, Nepal highlighted the importance of efficient collaboration between government and non-government agencies to eliminate child marriage in Nepal by 2030.

Citizens queuing up to fill biometrics in Mahottari

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Bardibas, Jan. 11

There has been a surge in the number of people coming to fill out biometrics forms for national identity cards at the local levels in Mahottari district.

The locals had to stand in a long queue when the authorities were unable to manage the crowd properly.

In some places, people had to return home without filling up their details even after waiting for hours for their turn.

According to Assistant Chief District Officer Upendra Neupane, currently, all the 15 municipalities of Mahottari, the Area Administrations and two places of the District Administration Office are collecting the details for the national ID. At the local level, most of the elderly people are visiting the ward offices while youth are visiting the administration and area administration offices to fill up the biometrics.

It is said that details of more than a thousand people are collected daily in all 15 local levels of Mahottari.

On the other hand, the Area Administration Office in Bardibas and Gaushala and the District Administration Office in Mahottari informed that up to 300 people come daily for biometrics.

As the number of people seeking National ID cards is increasing, Samsi Rural Municipality has designated alternate days for each ward number to come to the office to fill up the biometric records. According to Chief Administrative Officer Ganesh Chandra Mishra of the Municipality, six wards of the Rural Municipality have been assigned six different days to fill up the biometric forms.

The crowd in the municipal office has also decreased after an alternate system was implemented," said Mishra.

Sunil Sharma, the head of the Area Administration Office, Bardibas, said that the office has implemented a token system to manage the crowd as up to 100 people a day started coming for biometrics. According to him, tokens for up to January 25 have been distributed to the locals.

The Area Administration Office, Gaushala, informed that about 19,845 citizens have filled up their biometric forms from the Gaushala office alone.

Kiran Nidhi Tiwari, Chief Administrative Officer of Bardibas Municipality, said that the number of people coming to fill out biometric forms has increased rapidly after biometric details were made mandatory to update the details of the social security allowance.

Court orders...

The actual name of Bomjan is Ram Lal Bomjan. Following the order of the court, Bomjan is taken to the Jaleshwar-based jail.

Sadan Adhikari, Registrar of the District Court, said that the District Attorney's Office demanded an order to send Bomjan to jail and begin the investigation against him keeping him in the jail.

In the case of Bomjan, Chief of the District Attorney Office, Kailash Dahal represented the plaintiff on behalf of the government and advocates Dr. Kunsang Lama, Ajaya Tamang, Mahanidhi Sedai, Amrit Kumar Lama and Dilip Kumar Jha debated on favour of Bomjan.

After listening to both sides, Judge Regmi ordered Bomjan to be sent to prison for the preliminary investigation. The Central Investigation Bureau (CIB) of Nepal Police handed over Bomjan to the Sarlahi District Police Office in Malangwa at 2:00 a.m. on Thursday. He was taken to the District Police Office by road.

Bomjan was accused of sexual gratification and child sexual exploitation by his followers. An arrest warrant was issued against him by the Sarlahi District Court on July 5, 2020. He is a permanent resident of Nijgadh Municipality-12, Ratanpuri, Bara.

A missing case of a woman against Bomjan is also registered in Bara, Bomjan's hometown.

Remittance growth helping...

Moderating y-o-y prices of commodities under ghee and oil, vegetables and meat and fish sub-categories coupled with two downward adjustments of petroleum product prices by Nepal Oil Corporation and a decline in prices of vegetables, fruits, spices and sugar compared to the previous month contributed to the subdued inflationary pressure in the review month.

During the review month, the y-o-y import price index declined by 3.3 per cent.

This was accompanied by moderating growth rates in both the salary and wage rate index and the wholesale price index which also contributed to a decline in consumer price inflation.

Under the Food and Beverage Category, the y-o-y price index of ghee and oil, vegetable and meat and fish sub-category decreased by 13.66 per cent, 8.37 per cent and 0.13 per cent respectively in the review month.

The y-o-y price index of spices sub-category increased by 37.22 per cent, fruit by 13.37 per cent, sugar and sugar products by 13.24 per cent, cereal grains and their products by 11.30 per cent, milk products and eggs by 10.59 per cent and pulses and legumes by 10.56 per cent.

During the review period, under the Non-Food and Services Category, y-o-y price index of the transportation sub-category decreased by 2.48 per cent.

Irish Upper...

The President also outlined sustainable economic development as a priority for Nepal and believed it would support the institutionalisation of democracy, inclusivity and federalism.

Seanad Éireann is the Upper House of the Irish legislature and Cathaoirleach is the position that leads it.

Stakeholders discuss ways to reduce human-wildlife conflict

BY JAYA KRISHNA YADAV
Inaruwa, Jan.11

Stakeholders in Sunsari district have emphasised the need for reducing human-animal conflict, originating from the rise in human population that leads to increasing demand for space resulting in constant encroachment of wildlife habitat.

During a dialogue programme on natural resource-based conflicts and methods of conflict transformation organised by the Centre for Social Change, the participants stressed the importance of collaborative efforts to mitigate conflicts between wildlife and humans.

During the programme held on Thursday, stakeholders emphasised that agreement was reached on community issues, resource consumption, and conservation.

However, conflicts persist between humans and wild animals in the Koshi Tappu Wildlife Reserve (KTWR) and people residing in the buffer zone areas, primarily due to specific legal provisions, practical considerations, and a lack of awareness.

Ramesh Kumar Yadav, the Chief Conservation Officer of KTWR, said that they were working to reduce the conflict between wildlife and humans, not only in the district but in the reserve and park areas all over the country.

Yadav stated that while arrangements were made for the people of KTWR to engage in grass-cutting and fishing, the conflict between wildlife and humans could be minimised if unauthorised grazing, deforestation, and hunting were reduced.

Aiyuv Ansari, the Chairman of Koshi Rural Municipality, expressed dissatisfaction, alleging that only the Chief Conservation Officers were getting the benefits of the KTWR while the local people bore the brunt of the situation.

Ansari pointed out that the lack of transparency in the reserve's budgets, the absence of coordination with the local community, and a growing trend of withholding information from local authorities, have worsened conflicts.

He said that transforming KTWR into a park would be a more favourable development approach. "If it becomes a park, the conflict between wild animals and humans will decrease to some extent," he added.

Dr. Prakash Bhattarai of Social Change Centre said that the disagreements between the KTWR and the people living around KTWR and the buffer zone should be addressed in two ways, short-term and long-term.

Ramesh Bhattarai, the Sunsari coordinator of the Centre, stressed that if a spirit of coordination, cooperation, and collaboration is nurtured among the Chief Conservation Officer, the chairman of the rural municipality, people's representatives and stakeholders, the conflict between wildlife and humans in this area could be mitigated to a large extent.

Rights activist Rabin Ghimire, conservationists Gopi Yadav, Bidi Lal Sarkar, Pinki Sardar, Rajkumar Sharma, Nasibullah Miya, Amin Nepali Miya, Pabarti Uraw, and Jageshwar Yadav talked about the issues of conflict between wildlife and humans.

Complexities of relationships and its detrimental effects: Pagla Ghoda

BY RENUKA DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 11





Four men from different walks of life gather for the funeral of a girl who has committed suicide.

While the girl's body is burning on the pyre, the four men indulge in cards and drinks, attempting to explore the mystery of her death. The girl, now a ghost, appears on the stage during the cremation and tries to communicate with the men about their love mysteries.

This is how the play 'Pagla Ghoda (The Wild Horse) begins.

Amidst the somber atmosphere of a crematorium ground, the four men gradually reveal the complexities of their own love stories, sharing the painful narratives of how they forever lost their loves and now grapple with haunting guilt.

The play, currently being staged at Mandala Theatre, delves into the complexities of relationships and the detrimental effects of deep-rooted societal and patriarchal ideologies.

The play revolves around four middle-class cowardly men who love their girls but can't accept going against societal norms because of their fearful reasons.

Renowned Indian theatre artist and director Badal Sircar penned the play 'Pagla Ghoda' in the 1960s. Translated by Shiva Khand Thakuri into Nepali, the play is directed by Ghanashyam Shrestha while Aashant Sharma supervised the script.

Sircar sought to explore the realities of society approximately six decades ago through his play.

Through this play, Sircar delved into the multifaceted aspects of society, shedding light on how women were treated in the name of culture and belief. His examination exposed the prevailing dominance of males over females, often leading to circumstances where women felt compelled to sacrifice their lives.

Ironically, the societal dynamics observed six decades ago remain prevalent even in today's society in various forms.

The play serves as a poignant reflection of the enduring suffering that women undergo due to embedded patriarchal norms.

In the narrative, Shekhar, a middle-class young man portrayed by Bijay Anand Tamrakar, is deeply in love with Sapana. However, he tragically forces Sapana into marrying his cousin Pradeep under the false belief that Pradeep reciprocates her feelings. This forced marriage leads to a tragic ending, with Sapana taking her own life.

Another couple, Ashok (Bimba Adhikari) and Maya, represents the clash between modernity and tradition. Maya, hailing from a wealthy background, falls in love with Ashok, a normal teacher. However, Ashok pressures her to follow traditional patriarchal norms, which leads Maya to commit suicide.

Rabi (Pramod Agrahari), a contractor, and Laxmi share a deep love for each other. However, he refuses to acknowledge their relationship to society, fearing the loss of his job. This ultimately results in Laxmi's heartbreaking demise.

The storyline also encompasses the story of a woman left alone on her wedding day, dedicating herself to the care of her paralysed father.

Despite her devotion, she becomes increasingly frustrated with her life. In her desperation, she encounters Kapil, portrayed by Ashanta Sharma, and asks for poison to end her life. Kapil, profoundly in love with her, pleads for seven days to change her mind, but tragically, she takes her own life before that time elapses.

The unfolding events reveal the deep-seated traumas and struggles within the souls of these four men, each narrating their stories through poignant memories.

All four dead girls' roles are played by actress Malika Mahat.

Although it is her first theatrical performance, she has tried her best to embody all four characters.

The other four men have also done commendable work in the play.

The title 'Pagla Ghoda' is a metaphor to convey its narrative. It symbolises the chaotic and unpredictable nature of love.

The parallel narratives in the play make the audience curious multiple times, and the love mysteries and twists and turns also engage the theatregoers in the play.

The play will be staged in Mandala Theatre till January 20.

Directors Guild nominates Greta Gerwig, Christopher Nolan, Martin Scorsese

AP
New York, Jan. 11

Christopher Nolan, Greta Gerwig and Martin Scorsese have been nominated by the Directors Guild for its top award.

The nominations to the 76th DGA Awards, which followed those by the Screen Actors Guild earlier Wednesday, went as expected. The other two nominees for the guild's top award, for outstanding directorial achievement, are Alexander Payne for "The Holdovers" and Yorgos Lanthimos for "Poor Things."

Nolan's nomination, for "Oppenheimer," is his fifth DGA nod though he's never won before. Gerwig, nominated for "Barbie," was previously nominated for 2017's "Lady Bird." Scorsese's nomination for "Killers of the Flower Moon" is his 13th DGA nod; he has previously won for 2006's "The Departed" and for the series "Boardwalk Empire."

The Directors Guild nominees often closely align with those of the Academy Awards. Over the past two decades, the winner of the DGA award has nearly always also triumphed at the Oscars. Last year, Daniel Kwan and Daniel Scheinert won both awards for "Everything Everywhere All at Once."

The DGA's nominees for first-time feature filmmaker went to Cord Jefferson for "American Fiction," Manuela Martelli for "Chile '76"," Noora Niasari for "Shayda," A.V. Rockwell for "A Thousand and One" and Celine Song for "Past Lives."

The guild earlier on Tuesday announced other categories. The DGA nominations for best documentary are: "20 Days in Mariupol," "Bobi Wine: The People's President," "Beyond Utopia," "Kokomo City" and "Still: A Michael J. Fox Movie." HBO's "Succession" led the TV nominations, with four out of five nominations for direction.

76th annual DGA Awards will be held Feb. 10.



Music streams hit 4 trillion in 2023

AP
los angeles, Jan. 11



Listened to more music last year? You're not alone.

The global music industry surpassed 4 trillion streams in 2023, a new single-year record, Luminate's 2023 Year-End Report found.

Global streams were also up 34% from last year, reflective of an increasingly international music marketplace. Stateside, three genres saw the biggest growth in 2023: country (23.7%), Latin (which encompasses all Latin musical genres, up 24.1%) and world (a catchall that includes J-pop, K-pop and Afrobeats, up 26.2%.)

It seems that more Americans are listening to non-English music. By the end of 2023, Luminate found that Spanish-language music's share of the top 10,000 songs streamed in the U.S. grew 3.8%, and English-language music's share dropped 3.8%.

Under the Latin umbrella, regional Mexican music saw massive growth. The genre term — which encompasses mariachi, banda, corridos, norteño, sierreño and other styles — grew 60% in U.S. on-demand audio streams, accounting for 21.9 billion. Four of the six Latin artists to break 1 billion audio streams in the U.S. were Mexican acts: Peso Pluma, Eslabon Armado, Junior H, and Fuerza Regida, who also placed in the top 125 artists streamed.

Armado and Peso Pluma's "Ella Baila Sola" surpassed a billion streams on Spotify in less than a year and became the first regional Mexican Top 10 hit on Billboard's all-genre Hot 100, peaking at No. 4 — later, Bad Bunny's collaboration with Grupo Frontera, "Un x100to," hit No. 5.

Selena Gomez announces break from Social Media

AGENCIES
New York, Jan. 11

Singer-actress Selena Gomez is taking a break from social media to focus on "what really matters."

The 31-year-old singer has announced that she's stepping back from social media, after she was recently accused of gossiping about Kylie Jenner and Timothee Chalamet's romance at the 2024 Golden Globes.

She wrote on her Instagram Story: "I'm off social for a while. I'm focusing on what really matters."

During the awards ceremony, Gomez was seen chatting to Taylor Swift and actress Keleigh Sperry, and fans subsequently speculated that they were talking about Kylie and Timothee's high-profile romance. But Selena has already rubbished that idea.

Responding to the speculation, Gomez, who has a huge social media following, recently wrote on Instagram: "No I told Taylor about two of my friends who hooked up. Not that that's anyone business," Meanwhile, Selena started dating Benny Blanco in 2023, and the she is said to be "super happy" with the record producer."

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: You're taking control of your life -- and others can see it! You may have gone through a period where it felt like every day brought a new problem, but you're finally able to find a rhythm that works for you.

TAURUS: You don't have to be a boxer to fight back! If someone is spreading unfair rumors about you or refusing to give you the credit that you deserve, then it's time to stand up for yourself.

GEMINI: Someone may be pushing you to act out of character. You know who you are inside, but there could be people around you who are trying to get you to show a nastier side of yourself.

CANCER: You might be competing against many other people throughout the day. Regardless of your typical attitude toward competition, when it comes to something that you really want.

LEO: You can let your hard work do the talking at the moment. A superior or an authority figure may begin questioning you, but you'd be wise to let your record speak for itself.

VIRGO: Who you are is enough, Virgo. You may currently base much of your worth on winning or reaching a certain standard that you set for yourself. Unfortunately, this can become stressful if you fall short of the standards.

LIBRA: Someone in your life potentially understands your needs -- whether you've known them for years or just met. Keep your eyes peeled for a business partner or advisor.

SCORPIO: You're a person that others can count on. There may be a call to action that comes for you during the day, either to serve people that you know personally or to assist the community at large.

SAGITTARIUS: Your dedication may beat out the talent of someone else. No matter how naturally gifted they are, you may have been more faithful to studying or practicing your skills.

CAPRICORN: Creativity is calling, Capricorn! You may have a bit of extra time to yourself at present, either for a vacation or just a day to rest. Either way, this means you have more freedom to follow your heart!

AQUARIUS: You might not want to contend with those who are trying to compete with you. While you're likely just expressing yourself the only way that you know how.

PISCES: You might find yourself competing for someone's time and attention. There may be multiple people trying to catch the eye of this person for one reason or another.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Nepal Police dethrone APF to clinch National Men's Volleyball title



PHOTO: NAVIN SUBEDI/TRN

Photo Caption: People throng at Khullamanch in Birendranagar, Surkhet, to watch the final match of the 34th edition of the National Men's Volleyball Competition between Nepal Police Club and APF Club on Thursday.

BY NAVIN SUBEDI
Surkhet, Jan. 11

Nepal Police Club won the 34th edition of the National Men's Volleyball Competition held in Birendranagar, Surkhet, defeating Armed Police Force (APF) Club 3-1 in the finals on Thursday.

APF had reached the finals remaining undefeated throughout the competition. Police had earlier lost its match against APF in the 15th group match of the edition. However, the only loss of the tournament cost APF the trophy in front of a massive crowd at Khullamanch in Birendranagar. People were seen sitting on verandas and terraces of nearby houses and on the top of several buses parked around the court acting as parapets.

While thousands were present on the ground to see the final match, thousands more were viewing it on Hamro Khelkud's Facebook page.

Title-defender APF as the undefeated team clinched the first set in the final match. However, Police made an exceptional comeback and won the next three sets to clinch the trophy.

It was the first tournament win for Nepal Police in volleyball in the ongoing Nepali Year 2080 despite qualifying for the finals in a total of seven tournaments, including the current one.

APF defeated Police 25-22 in the first set. But the hopes of APF started shaking as Police defeated APF in the second set 25-19. Moreover, APF lost 18-25 in the third. The fourth set was the most competitive one. Nevertheless, it ended 25-23 in favour of Police. After winning three sets, Nepal Police Club was announced as the winner.

Police's spikers Rabin Chand and Pahal Gahatraj were adjudged the best player and emerging player of the tournament respectively. Likewise, Hemanta Malla of APF, Im Bahadur Rana of Police, Rabin Nagarkoti of Police, Jeevan Sunar of Gandaki, Bhim Bahadur Gaha of Police and Chandra Kunwar of Police were declared as the best spiker, setter, blocker, server, libero and coach respectively.

On the other hand, Gandaki won against Tribhuwan Army in the match for third place on Thursday. Army could only win one set while Gandaki won three. In the group stage, Army defeated Gandaki by winning the first three sets.

Meanwhile, the match for third place ended as Gandaki won the first set by 25-22 and the third and fourth sets by 26-24 and 25-22 respectively. Army only won the second set with the score 26-24.

The competition started on January 5 between 10 teams – three departmental and seven provincial teams – in a league format by forming two groups of five teams each. The top teams of the two groups played the semi-finals against the second-positioned teams in the opposite group.

Group A topper APF won its semi-final match against Gandaki and Group A runners up Police defeated Tribhuwan Army Club in the other last four match on Wednesday.

Real edge Atletico to reach Super Cup final

AFP
Riyadh, Jan. 11

Real Madrid defeated Atletico Madrid 5-3 after extra-time in a pulsating battle in Saudi Arabia to reach the Spanish Super Cup final on Wednesday.

Mario Hermoso and Antonio Rudiger exchanged early headed goals before Ferland Mendy sent Madrid ahead at the Al-Awwal Park stadium in Riyadh.

Antoine Griezmann levelled with a milestone goal for Atletico to become their all-time leading scorer and Kepa Arrizabalaga's own goal sent the Rojilbancos ahead, but Dani Carvajal smashed Madrid level and forced extra-time.

With the game heading towards penalties, Stefan Savic's own goal under pressure from Joselu nudged Madrid ahead and substitute Brahim Diaz wrapped up the win on the counter-attack with Atletico goalkeeper Jan Oblak stranded out of position.

In Sunday's final Madrid will face either Barcelona or Osasuna, who meet Thursday in the other semi-final.

"Atletico played very well and so did we, it was a spectacular game," Madrid coach Carlo Ancelotti told Movistar.

"We won because we had more energy in the final stages ... (the substitutes) all delivered."

Diego Simeone's Atletico are the only team to beat Madrid this season, in September, and they started strongly with Samuel Lino testing Arrizabalaga shortly before they took the lead.

Liverpool comeback

Liverpool produced another comeback after conceding first to take a 2-1 lead over Fulham into the second leg of their League Cup semi-final on Wednesday.

Willian fired the visitors in front in their first ever League Cup semi-final at Anfield.

But two goals in three second-half minutes from Curtis Jones and Cody Gakpo gave the Reds a slender advantage ahead of the second leg at Craven Cottage on January 24.

Jurgen Klopp's men have now fallen behind in 14 games this season, but have won seven of those matches and lost just three.

"It's the mentality in the group, in the club, in the city. Everybody is like this," said Gakpo. Liverpool remain the strong favourites to reach the Wembley final against either Middlesbrough or Chelsea next month. However, Fulham do have hope with home advantage to come in the second leg.

Atalanta into Cup semis

Atalanta set up an Italian Cup semi-final with Fiorentina after winning 2-1 at AC Milan on Wednesday, while Lazio won 1-0 in a fiery derby with Roma which finished with three red cards. Teun Koopmeiners struck either side of half-time of an entertaining quarter-final to continue Atalanta's bid for a first major trophy since 1963, when they last won the competition.

"We have have done so much in recent years," said Atalanta coach Gian Piero Gasperini. "We might not have any silverware... but we have reached the Italian Cup final in the past and we want to go all the way."



PHOTO: AP

Real Madrid's Antonio Rudiger, right, celebrates scoring their first goal with Jude Bellingham during the Semi Final of Spanish Super Cup match against Atletico Madrid in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia.

SNIPPETS

CAN suspends cricketer Sandeep

Kathmandu (TRN): The Cricket Association of Nepal (CAN) has suspended rape convict Sandeep Lamichhane from every form of domestic and international cricket tournament. Lamichhane was sentenced to eight years in prison by the Kathmandu District Court on January 11. While he was already found guilty by the court on December 29, 2023, the punishment's verdict came on Wednesday. The rape case was lodged against Lamichhane at the district court on October 31, 2022.

Issuing a press statement, which is signed by CAN's chairman Chatur Bahadur Chand, on Thursday, CAN informed that the suspension was a result of Lamichhane found guilty by the court. CAN had earlier allowed Lamichhane to represent Nepal in different tournaments despite the rape charges and the case under proceeding at the court citing that he was not proven guilty. Lamichhane, who also once captained the national men's cricket team, has said to knock on the door of a higher court to challenge the district court's verdict.

12 teams unveiled for Aaha! Rara Gold Cup

Kathmandu (TRN): Organisers have made public the 12 teams participating in the 23rd Aaha! Rara Gold Cup. The 23rd edition has been slated for January 23 to February 3. As per the team list, eight A-Division teams and two foreign teams will be vying for the cup with Sahara Club, the organiser, and Rising Star FC Sunuwal, a club based in Nawalpur district. The eight A-Division teams include Sankata Club, Church Boys United, Machhindra FC, Tribhuwan Army Football Club, Manag Marshyangdi Club, Nepal Police Club, Jawalakhel Youth Club and Three Star Club. Similarly, Delhi Football Club, a team playing in the Indian I-League, and Paro Football Club of Bhutan are taking part in the competition. The tournament is being organised by Sahara Football Academy in support of Surya Bahadur KC Memorial. Pokhara Stadium will host the competition.

Prince, Bishnu advance

Kathmandu (TRN): Prince Dahal of APF Club and Bishnu Katuwal of Nepal Police Club (NPC) advanced to the quarterfinals in men's singles at the 1st Prakash Dahal Memorial National Badminton Tournament in Kathmandu on Thursday. Dahal defeated his clubmate Sujan Thapa 21-11, 21-10 to advance while Katuwal overcame Sunil Karki of Sports Hub 21-7, 25-3 in the pre-quarterfinals. Sunil Joshi of NPC, Kabir KC of Tribhuvan Army Club (TAC), Devraj Rana of APF, Anil Malla of APF, Praful Maharjan of TAC and Bibek Chaudhary of APF also booked their berth in the last eight. Similarly, Nita Lamsal of NPC, Amita Giri of TAC, Sheshna Shripali of TAC, Sima Rajbanshi of Kasturi College, Shova Gauchan of APF, Rihana Sherchan of TAC and Anumaya Rai of TAC marched into quarterfinals of women's singles.

Son set to light up Asian Cup as Qatar takes centre stage again

AFP
Doha, Jan. 11

The Asian Cup begins on Friday with defending champions Qatar the hosts, Japan favourites and Son Heung-min's South Korea vowing to win the title for the first time in 64 years.

The 24 teams spanning Australia to Palestine will battle for regional glory over the next four weeks, culminating in the final at the 88,000-capacity Lusail Stadium on February 10.

It will take something special to beat the last big game at Lusail -- the World Cup final 13 months ago when an Argentina side inspired by Lionel Messi defeated France on penalties.

The 18th edition of the Asian Cup was supposed to have been held last summer in China but was moved to World Cup host Qatar because of China's Covid-19 rules.

Qatar will mostly use stadiums that staged World Cup matches, a notable absentee being Stadium 974, the temporary arena made partly of shipping containers.

In the lead-up to the World Cup, the Gulf state came under intense scrutiny over its human rights record and treatment of migrant workers.

Rights groups say little has changed since, something Qatar disputes. There has been no such outcry ahead of the Asian Cup.

Japan vow to erase 'frustration'

Qatar won plaudits for its organisation of the World Cup but the team flopped on the pitch, their three straight defeats the worst performance of any World Cup host.

That lingering pain will motivate them in the defence of their Asian crown, but Carlos Queiroz was fired as coach only last month, giving replacement Tintin Marquez little time to prepare.

"I know the players, I know my mentality and I know... my idea for playing," said the Spaniard, who coached Qatar club side Al Wakrah for six years before taking over the national team. Qatar open the tournament against Lebanon at Lusail Stadium.

There are six groups of four, the top two from each reaching the last 16, along with the four best third-placed teams.

Japan, defeated 3-1 by Qatar in the 2019 final in the UAE, look the team to beat and are the most successful side in Asian Cup history with four titles.

Banners bearing the images of the Asian Cup mascots displayed on buildings in the Qatari capital Doha Japan have fond memories of Qatar, having stunned Germany and Spain in the group stage of the World Cup before losing to Croatia on penalties in the last 16. Hajime Moriyasu's team have enjoyed a strong year since, losing only once in 12 matches and winning 4-1 in Germany in a friendly.

Moriyasu named Kaoru Mitoma in his squad despite the Brighton winger suffering an ankle injury and said that Japan are determined to erase the "frustration" of their 2019 final loss.

All or nothing for Klinsmann

South Korea, Iran, Australia and Saudi Arabia -- all of whom played at the 2022 World Cup and are former Asian champions -- are also teams to watch.

In Tottenham Hotspur attacker Son, South Korea have the best player in Asia and a world-class performer who is enjoying his football again under Spurs manager Ange Postecoglou. South Korean fans were sceptical about the appointment nearly a year ago of legendary German striker Jurgen Klinsmann, given his patchy record as a coach.

But after a slow start his side have hit their stride, their last competitive match a 3-0 World Cup qualifying win in China with Son scoring twice and setting up the third. The 59-year-old Klinsmann has said anything other than winning the Asian Cup for the first time since 1960 will be a failure.

"It's 64 years -- 64 years is a long time for Korea. It's about time that we get this done," said Klinsmann.

There will be extra interest in how Saudi Arabia -- coached by the Italian Roberto Mancini -- get on following an influx of foreign stars into their domestic football led by Cristiano Ronaldo.

The Palestinian team face an uphill task to emerge from a group containing Iran, United Arab Emirates and Hong Kong, with their minds on the war in Gaza, in which some players have lost loved ones.

"Everyone is glued to the news, before and after training, be it on the bus or at the hotel," coach Makram Daboub said.

This will be Palestine's third time at the Asian Cup and they are chasing a first victory after failing to win any of their six matches so far.



WEATHER

Friday

Sunrise at 6:56 am, Sunset at 5:28 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Friday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly regions of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province and mainly fair in rest of the country.

Expected Temp.: 18 - 20°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Thursday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	17.8	4.5	0.0
Dipayal	24.2	4.0	0.0
Dhangadi	12.1	8.5	0.0
Birendranagar	22.1	4.9	0.0
Nepalgunj	15.7	7.7	0.0
Jumla	17.7	-5.9	0.0
Ghorahi	18.1	7.5	0.0
Pokhara	17.2	9.0	0.0
Bhairahawa	18.4	8.2	0.0
Simara	18.3	9.2	0.0
Kathmandu	17.3	5.6	0.0
Okhaldhunga	17.7	6.2	0.0
Taplejung	16.4	5.9	0.0
Dhankuta	21.5	8.2	0.0
Biratnagar	14.3	11.5	0.0
Jomsom	14.0	-4.0	0.0*
Dharan	14.0	10.0	0.0*
Lumle	17.5	5.0	0.0*
Janakpur	15.2	11.0	0.0*
Jiri	14.9	-1.1	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 12, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.55	Rs. 133.15
Euro	1	Rs. 145.55	Rs. 146.21
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 169.18	Rs. 169.95
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 155.79	Rs. 156.49
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 88.98	Rs. 89.38
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 99.14	Rs. 99.59
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.71	Rs. 100.17
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.12	Rs. 9.16
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.51	Rs. 18.60
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.35	Rs. 35.51
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.35	Rs. 36.51
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.78	Rs. 3.80
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.09	Rs. 36.25
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.53	Rs. 28.66
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.08	Rs. 10.12
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.99	Rs. 13.05
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.52	Rs. 19.61
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.95	Rs. 17.03
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.37	Rs. 433.32
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.61	Rs. 353.21

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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THE RISING NEPAL

Friday

SUPPLEMENT

Friday, January 12, 2024

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Women Entrepreneurs Need Support



Modnath Dhakal

> The institutions working in the areas of women's rights should also collaborate with the Ministry of Industry, Commerce, and Supplies and the Ministry of Finance to create and implement more impactful programmes that could economically empower women.

Of the 6.66 million households, 31 per cent headed by women members of the family, and more than 51 per cent of the population are women, but only 23.8 per cent of them own a piece of land or a house. However, this achievement is the result of the impact of foreign employment and the split in the family, primarily in the districts affected by the 2015 Gorkha earthquake, where families were broken apart to claim the housing grant of Rs. 300,000 offered by the government for reconstruction of the house damaged in the tremors. Likewise, 31 women per 100 cannot read and write, while the number of males who are illiterate is 16 per 100, according to the National Census 2021.

Similarly, the Economic Census 2018 showed that about 29.8 per cent of the total 923,356 business firms run in the country were owned or managed by women. But women-run businesses earn slightly above a quarter of the business firms managed by men; female-led businesses earn an average annual profit of Rs. 343,000, which is quite modest compared to the average profit of Rs. 1.2 million of the male-led enterprises.

Since informality incidence is high among women-run firms, they are deprived of various offers, benefits, and discounts announced by the government and Nepal Rastra Bank. For example, many informal businesses couldn't obtain facilities like discounts and wave-offs on bank interest rates, refinancing, and other subsidies, as such facilities were available only to formal businesses. Many cottage and small entrepreneurs neither know about the funds and support mechanisms created by the government nor have access to them. During the recent economic slowdown, a substantial number of micro-cottages and small enterprises managed by women had to shut down temporarily or permanently, as estimated by the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FNCCI). The impact of this economic hit is not only affecting men but also women in their attempts to venture into entrepreneurship.

This reality underscores the need to promote the participation of women in business and industries, not only to economically empower women but also to create an equitable and just society.

Since women have been traditionally discriminated against on social, economic, and political fronts, positive discrimination is needed to create a more egalitarian society in terms of gender development. Since the government has adopted the policy of poverty alleviation through entrepreneurship promotion and job creation, the inclusion of women in this drive can help expedite the results and achieve the national goal. The World Trade Organisation has maintained that trade policies can affect men and women differently, with women facing higher obstacles to taking part in the global economy and trade.



Poor execution of policies

Bureaucratic hassles and dillydallying disappointed women entrepreneurs while obtaining incentives on exports from the government, as the process needs multiple days with multiple rounds of banks, customs offices, and business chambers of the Department of Industry. Owing to it, many women entrepreneurs have distanced themselves from the process of obtaining incentives.

Since many women operate small and medium enterprises, they don't directly export their products but instead do it through an exporter, which has benefited the traders as the incentives on the exports are given to the exporters, not the producers. But the government agencies have shown apathy to the issue and continue to defend themselves with incentives and policies that are not gender-exclusive but are for all. Some high officials said that there is no gender in trade, while many East Asian and African countries have devised gender-friendly trade policies for domestic and regional trade.

Government-announced funds and facilities like the Industry and Investment Promotion Fund and e-haat bazar have not come into operation even after a couple of years since their announcement. The government, through its budget, had also announced a plan to establish a women's craft village at the Bhrikuti Exhibition Centre in Kathmandu, which couldn't materialise, while the financial support for women entrepreneurs to participate in international trade fairs has also been diminishing.

Initiatives for future

Nepal's Women, Business, and Law score of 80.6, as per the World Bank's 2023 report, suggests a relatively favourable environment. The government is developing the Micro, Cottage, and Small Industries Promotion Policy, 2080, to boost access for women, minorities, Dalits, and differently abled individuals in MCSEs. The policy includes provisions for concessional loans, capacity-building, competitiveness enhancement, and support for handicraft industries, which are likely to support women in business as well. However, this document doesn't have exclusive policies or provisions for women in business.

Meanwhile, the National Startup Enterprise Policy's progress is halted at the Ministry of Finance, affecting overall startup promotion. Ensuring legal political representation is one side, but for promoting women's entrepreneurship, there need to be developers in finance, technical background operations, and marketing. Collaboration is key to increasing the effectiveness of women in all areas, including economic, social, and political aspects. But the idea has not been adopted by policymakers and political leaders in Nepal.

The Women Ministry and Women Commission of Nepal are more focused on violence against women and other social maladies but have poor engagement in economic activities. However, right-based institutions and mechanisms help in the protection, self-respect, and empowerment of women, which ultimately boost their confidence to start or participate in a business. The institutions working in the areas of women's rights should also collaborate with the Ministry of Industry, Commerce, and Supplies and the Ministry of Finance to create and implement more impactful programmes that could economically empower women. Economic empowerment can enhance decision-making capability, social and political resilience, and the strength to fight for other rights.

(Dhakal is a journalist at The Rising Nepal)

Constitutional Rollercoaster Ride



Rameshwar Baral

The street had briefly hosted a lively, humorous scene. Some playful kids chased a cyclist who passionately chanted, 'Ram! Ram!' In jest, they teased his deity by chanting, 'Krishna! Krishna!' They would shout, 'Your bicycle has Krishna!' The rider promptly dumped the bike on the street and chanted 'Ram! Ram!' to lift back his ride with penance, as if his deity alone were superior. This amusing cycle of teasing and penance continued. Onlookers found it entertaining until he finally rode off.

Some individuals might find themselves in a dilemma, the constitution of the Sanatan Dharma being the reason. In fact, Ram or Krishna is the same deity, no less than the other in the unwritten constitution. Chanting any name is equally supreme. The devotee was bold and confident, as were the kids in Jest. This incident is comparable to Nepal's constitutional journey as a rollercoaster ride. Nepal has cycled through a series of six constitutions over the past six decades. The land is the same, and the people are the same, but the constitution is much like a bicycle, once dumped and then picked up. Now, the constitution has its seventh version. The former six were impeached and overturned, as none had ground reality. During the change, a couple of them had seismic turbulence on the Richter scale. In a democracy, people's anger and protests often overturn the law of the land. The demise of a constitution is a hypothesis about a nation's progress.

Thus, Nepal now picks up the seventh law, known as the Constitution of Nepal. Evidently, it promises smooth and good governance for the Republican nation. Hence, the previous six were dumped like lesser deities. This one has come into effect like old shoe pairs replaced successively.

The constitution is democratic, following the practice of general elections. Representatives come to the parliament through the processes. Voters view them as committed to working tirelessly for the nation's development and welfare. The masses feel that the leaders have experience, ideals, and vision.

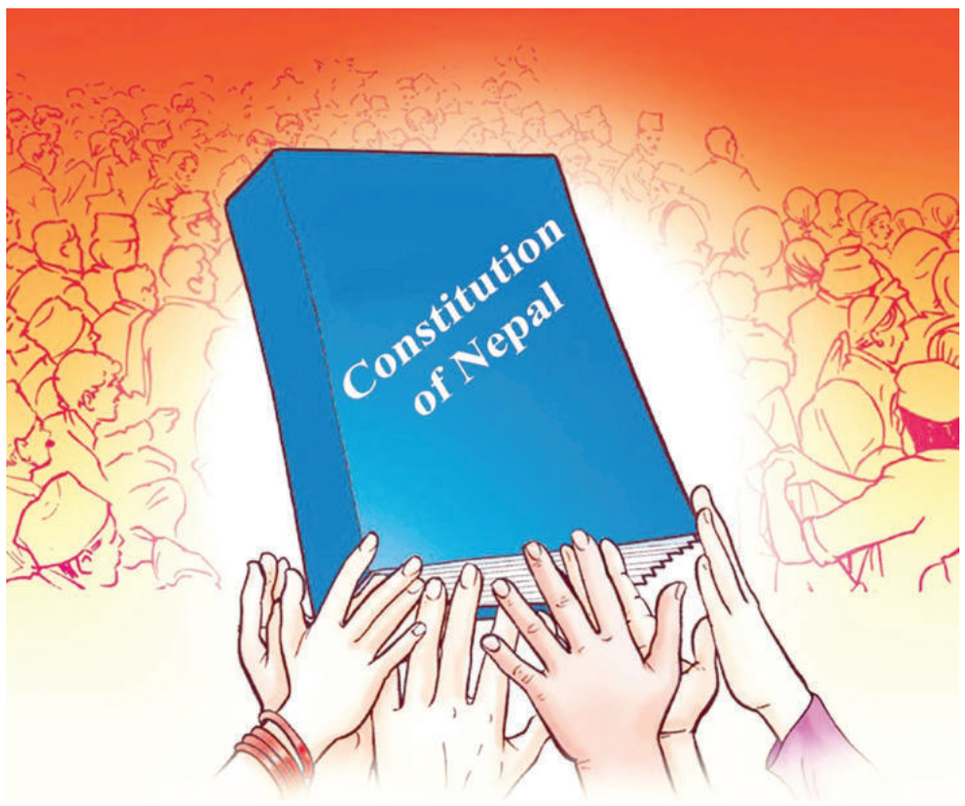
Leaders worked under earlier provisions too. They were all lesser gods, though leaders were not dumped. The current constitution now holds the leaders directly accountable.

While leaders take pride in being its architects, they are grappling with complex processes. Critics and the media spark a debate, arguing, 'The nation, landscape, and transition remain unchanged when the constitution changes successively. The same irony echoes until today, seventy years after the Ranas.' The ground reality of leaders and the constitution both prompt an open question: 'Are leaders ineffective?'

Previous constitutions, too, had the same ego. All claimed that they were not lesser but a supreme god for the nation's overall transformation. Miserably, all were disgraced with no pass score. In that sense, they faced impeachment when the current one had the claim of the least unworkable provisions and was ensured to be positive and effective. Under this practice, leaders are staggering against heavy electioneering expenses.

Nonetheless, the question remains: where is the nation, and where are the trends? An overall review of economic, social, or political contexts is just negative. A likely escape from this situation that leaders claim is, "The nations are in the phase of transition!" The catchword of transition is not new because people know a nation was in transition under all the previous constitutions. It means the transition phase continues until today!

This is a scene comparable to dumping the bike and lifting it again. If the bike is the written constitution, the unwritten part proclaims lesser deities. The unwritten world is one of virtual ethics, commitment, and vision with ground reality. Ethics is an individual leader's inner quality pointer to being on the ground with the people. In contrast, leaders have set up a different ground. So, two contrasting narratives now come into view. One is Facebook, and the other is BankBook. Facebook symbolises public comments on the present corrupt scenario. The bankbook symbolises record-breaking, disgraced corruption. Such examples are numerous, say nepotism, Bhutan refugees, gold smuggling, Ncell, etc. Now a bigger terror is devouring the nation; her frontiers have turned volatile and vulnerable. Observers ask: How long shall expatriates and remittance workers sustain the nation's economy?



Leaders as well as the masses have the same biting echo: "The nation is off track." Viewers critically observe that the constitution and leaders have no coordination. Clearly, then, who bears the lapses and who should be impeached? Is it the bike to be dumped or its riders? When the deity the leaders are chanting is supreme, they also have to prove they should not or need not dump the bike.

Keep riding the bike, affirming that the deity they worship is supreme. In this case, the riders (who are leaders) stand questionable. Moral virtues like being clean against corruption, having a vision for the nation, and being committed are just a few examples of an unwritten constitution. If it is said that both the constitution and leaders are immune, then leaders are still its guinea pig.



Again, if the leaders say, "We're clean," they are not subject to being impeached. In that case, the constitution calls for impeachment. But leaders claim, 'we are the father of the constitution." This conflict is unending.

In the viewers' claim, a nation's transformations so far are time-given, not leader-made. In truth, no bike or its rider could have obstructed them. Transformations as such are like a burst of population, a rise in literacy, education, and awareness, and the absence of jobs. This hypothesis is against those leaders who have turned into Your Majesty against the only monarch on the throne. Therefore, two books are open against them. One is Facebook, and the other is BankBook. But they still shrink back from past ground realities.

> Leaders fail, but never again does the constitution. Never hypothesise that a nation fails, as it is not like partisan gods.

By now, they have forgotten about themselves, like who they were before. To know who they were, they could post their photo on the wall before they were into politics. That is their vital statistic today, which displays an ultra-convenient living standard. No other photo of the unprivileged masses is required. The burst of street public is like a volcano erupting in an unwritten constitution.

Assume for a short while that the masses are not against the constitution. Is then a leader subject to being dumped? Besides this, if leaders fail to defend themselves or convince the masses, the constitution itself is the guinea pig. Neither the ruling nor opposition benches have a resolution, although both are found battling with words against each other. The media is there to update this all for the unprivileged masses.

In the party system, leaders are leaders with experience in governance, such as making the constitution, driving party workers, making sacrifices for the nation's common cause, and having the capacity to unite national forces. Desperately, no final say emerges, and all are conflict-ridden among themselves.

It's like Anton Chekhov said about a learned prisoner in his story: first catching at one spar and then at another, amidst the wreckage of the ship in the deep sea (The Bet). Leaders fail, but never again does the constitution. Never hypothesise that a nation fails, as it is not like partisan gods. The show continues, though not logically.

(The writer is a retired lecturer of English.)

Nourish Dreams, Defeat Hunger



Saroj Acharya

When the lunch bell rings, you can hear the blissful cries of children with big smiles on their faces, eagerly waiting in line to receive their piping hot meals. Tummies filled with locally palatable food, their personalities shine with beautiful smiles, and their joyous chit chat will soothe your soul.

The dedicated kitchen team members behind ISKCON Nepal work tirelessly each day to prepare food for the 26 community schools in Budhanilkantha and Tokha Municipalities. Their skill and commitment make it possible to provide nourishing meals for the students in these areas. For the past nine years since its genesis, Food for Life Nepal has worked for the welfare of children. Since the construction of a centralised modular kitchen with state-of-the-art technology by the Embassy of Japan in 2019, the 'School Lunch Preparation Centre' has operated as a centralised kitchen. If, by chance, you happen to walk by the area at 6 a.m. in the morning, you can hear heavy utensils clanking. These sounds are resonating far and wide, signifying warm meals being cooked for the little students.

Proper nutrition is important for children's intellectual and physical growth. The organisation realises that schoolchildren perform better academically with a nutritious meal filling their stomachs; this philosophy is why Food for Life Nepal existed in the first place. It serves humanity by providing nutritious meals to the community, especially to needy children. The organisation started by serving meals to a relatively small number of 18 children in 2014. Today, the organisation serves over 10,000 meals every school day to government schoolchildren.





There are approximately 3,500,000 students in public schools all over Nepal. The majority of the students who are enrolled in government schools are from financially challenged backgrounds. The government schools have been facing challenges in providing meals to students, with budget being the primary concern. To address this issue, the Ministry of Education, Science, and Technology started the programme 'Diva Khaja' under the national budget in 2017, where each student would be allocated Rs. 15 per child, which was a huge step towards eliminating classroom hunger. Though this was a commendable move due to inflation and rising costs, the fund was not sufficient for a proper, nutritious meal.

The organisation contacts the school administrators and implements their mid-day meal plan for schools in need of the 'Diva Khaja' programme. This programme features six meals for six days (except for government holidays), ensuring that students in the school get to fill their stomachs without having to compromise their health by relying on junk food. The programme's positive impact was evident in enhanced academic performance as proper nutrition improved the health status of the children. This, in turn, fostered regular attendance at school, ensuring a consistent and uninterrupted learning experience for the students.

The organisation is not only limited to deprived schoolchildren; they have also expanded their operations by featuring packages like the meals for the frontline pack. This provision ensured that the frontline health workers got the nutrition they deserved during the peak of COVID-19. Around 20,000 frontline workers got proper meals during such a precarious period. Soon after the registration of the organisation in 2015, an earthquake hit Nepal with strong blows. Our team sprang into action to set up relief kitchens that served more than 3,00,000 earthquake victims over the course of a month, situated at different locations such as Nuwakot, Panauti, Bhaktapur, Tudhikhel, Sakhu, Budhanilkantha, etc. Not only that, they had also set up 44 shelters for earthquake victims. The organisation had also announced the giveaway of Happiness Kits in 2020, which helped the schoolchildren keep up with stationary requirements and encouraged them to attend classes after more than a year and a half of social distancing. It has hosted other significant activities, such as awareness campaigns, clothes drives, and dental hygiene awareness programmes, for the overall holistic development of children and community schools.

Aiming to eradicate hunger as a barrier to education, the organisation aspires to expand its reach and ensure no child in Nepal faces educational deprivation due to hunger. With a strong commitment to serving the hungry, it has gained support from prominent international organisations, including Dr. Jacob's Medical, and local bodies. Kumari Bank Limited had also sponsored meals for the children of Jana Jagriti Secondary School in 2022. By relieving children of concerns about their stomachs, the organisation enables them to concentrate on their aspirations for success. The goal is to support the dreams of 25,000 children daily within the next decade.

(The author is an Executive Manager at Food for Life Nepal.)

Shanghai's Education Success: Lessons For Nepal



Baburam Thapa



Dinesh Kumar Thapa



In recent times, statistics and narratives on educational success are often cited from Shanghai, China, for having a highly successful education system, as evidenced by its students' strong performance in international assessments such as the Programme for International Student Assessment (PISA) that concerns students' performance in reading, mathematics, and sciences, as well as in the Teaching and Learning International Survey (TALIS) regarding teachers' professional practices, job satisfaction, collaboration with colleagues, professional development opportunities, and other factors that contribute to the overall teaching and learning environment. The scribe duos participated in the "Integrated Training of Teachers Before and After Service" organised by the UNESCO Teacher Education Centre and Shanghai Normal University with support from Shanghai Municipal Council from November 9–20, 2023. This article attempts to highlight the key features backing up the successful educational landscape of Shanghai, China, and the implications Nepalese educational policymakers, educators, and teachers can draw from Shanghai's education system.

Involvement and observations

The 'Belt and Road Shanghai Exchange Project on Integrated Training of Teachers Before and After Service' project was organised with the aim of exploring system design and performance mechanisms of pre-service training and life-long development of teachers through the exchange of knowledge, ideas, and experiences among education administrators, university educators, researchers, principals, and teachers from the Belt and Road countries. The programme was comprised of two modules: the first was dedicated to discussing the process and outcomes for excellence in teacher education through seminars and lectures, and the other was directed to experiencing the implementation of educational programmes at school and classroom levels for quality students' learning.

Research sharing and presentations during the project highlighted how Shanghai attracts the best talents in teacher education programmes, prepares able teachers, and provides continuous teacher development opportunities while teachers are in service. The seminars gave us the idea that quality education is never an accident, but it is always the result of intelligent effort. We understood that a strong and systemic collaboration between the Normal University, which prepares teachers, teacher educators, and educational researchers, and schools, which implement the educational programmes, is the precursor to quality teacher preparation. There are about 100 normal universities in China, which intensively collaborate with governments and schools across the country in preparing the required strength of educational human resources to realise the goal of 'developing students morally, educationally, and physically to make them both "red" (loyal to the party) and "expert" (well-educated and trained for the job)".

Like in other provinces, Shanghai too has placed aspiring candidates through open competition in the bachelor and master level programmes in education. The normal universities offer rigorous courses on core and specialisation subjects differently for elementary and secondary levels of education. One remarkable feature of the university courses is the provision of intense and rigorous internships, which the students need to complete by working in schools. The interns are well tended to by mentor teachers and are monitored and supported regularly in their teaching activities. Graduates, thus, would develop the philosophy, knowledge, and skills required for implementing the ambitious curricula and standards and educating the children of Shanghai, who perform excellently in academics, ethics, and life skills.

Our exposure to schools and classrooms gave us the realisation that, with adequate educational infrastructure and the dedication of the teachers and students, it is possible to harness the extreme talents in children. We found the school curricula were well balanced with their focus on literacy, numeracy, physical education, moral education, and service education. Service education started right in the third grade, which would connect the students to topics related to domestic and industrial production. Topics related to history, geography, culture, the Chinese Communist Party, national pride, heritage, tradition, and modernity were incorporated into moral education. We also learned that there was an equal focus on the skills of arts, calligraphy, dramatics, music, and athletics in the elementary level of education, which would provide the foundation of expression, virtuosity, and all-round development in the children. We were spellbound by the excellent performances of elementary school children at Shannan Elementary School,Anhui, a partner school of Huainan Normal University. The school was highly spacious and well equipped for individual and group learning and performances. Investment in buildings, classrooms, tools, playgrounds, and equipment was praiseworthy. When the children reached the secondary level, the focus seemed to shift to physics, mathematics, and modern languages, while maintaining studies in moral education and service education continuously. We could sense a visible linkage between mental, moral, and physical development as well as production and industry at the secondary level of school education. At Pudong Secondary School, Shanghai, we found a harmonious blend of culture and science, tradition and modernity, and arts and morality in the students and teachers. In addition to laboratory work, experiments, sports, and the arts, we found that Pudong School, which was one of the partner schools of Shanghai Normal University, had well-managed counselling sessions, therapy, extended study time, coaching on specific areas, etc. for the students. Teachers' performance was also standardised, with a heavy emphasis on the planning of materials and lesson activities before classroom delivery. Besides the conventional academic subjects, students also learned national pride, production, self-management, and volunteer spirit.

Learning for Nepal: smart education policy

The project led us to contemplate and reflect on how an education system can yield excellent results. The inspiring words of Professor Dr. Minxuan Zhang, Head of the Teacher Education Centre, UNESCO, resonate that a successful education system could only be built on the sound foundation of the soil of the nation and shaped by the needs and priorities of the nation. China at present is a reality of miracles in infrastructure, manufacturing, massive production, and efficient management. ' From 'P' [pin] to 'P' [plane] is the slogan of the Chinese, and Shanghai, being an industrial and commercial hub in east-central China, has no less aspirations to realise among its students. Shanghai, a city of about 23 million people, has now achieved complete primary and junior high school enrollment, and it is the first city in China to achieve almost universal secondary school attendance. At present, 80 per cent of children are studying in the public education system, and the rest are in international schools. Backing up these successes, Professor Bo Ning, the coordinator of the project, shared the immense role of Shanghai Normal University and the Teacher Education Centre, UNESCO, which work in collaboration with the Shanghai Municipal Education Commission to carry out research in teacher education, organise exchange programmes, and promote reforms in education through innovative teaching methods to improve teachers' capability. At this juncture, we conclude that it is only through collaboration and commitment that education policies result in excellent learning.

Our involvement in the Shanghai Project gave us some insights that might be key strategies for possible reforms in education in Nepal. We conclude that an efficient education system and transformation can be achieved only with a comprehensive reform, including reforms in policies, financing, teacher development, and having proper standards of curricula, assessments, work processes, and mechanisms of check and balance in place. Likewise, we reflect that educational policies and programmes recognise the role of the teacher workforce, regard teaching as an attractive and respected profession, and have clear career advancement mechanisms in place wherein teachers are supported and evaluated systematically to improve performance.

Our reflection further led us to the conclusion that teachers need to be highly qualified and well-trained through rigorous pre-service training and well-supported in-service professional development so that they can improve their instructional activities to evaluate and modify their own pedagogy in relation to student outcomes. Our learning also suggests that the curriculum should be carefully designed to cover key academic concepts and skills with a balance of subject-specific knowledge and skills, vocational and career skills, critical thinking, and problem-solving skills. We also contend that the education system recognises and involves parents at a high level, tapping their enormous cultural values, time, resources, and support for students' learning.

Finally, we deeply hold that schools should become a fulfilling space for the students wherein their mental, physical, vocational, and moral spheres are developed through their regular and extended involvement in academics, sports, athletics, arts, drama, production, and welfare-related activities.

(Babu Ram is the Chief Advisor of the Confederation of Nepalese Teachers, and Dinesh Kumar is a PhD Fellow at the School of Education, Kathmandu University.)

Insights Of A Civil Servant On Corruption



Madan Kumar Bhattarai

Corruption is possibly one area in Nepal that everybody, from politician to administrator, lawyer to judge, and even civil society to the ordinary person, professes to focus on and reduce, if not totally eradicate. It is also accepted that the phenomenon of corruption exists in some form or manifestation, from family to public life. This may range from outright bribery to policy-level corruption and even aspects of social life not taken that seriously in the ordinary sense of the term.

Ram Kumar Acharya, a retired special class officer of the Nepal Judicial Service with a Master of Laws from Bond University, Australia, has made a solid effort to highlight different aspects and manifestations of corruption in the global context in general and its special impact on Nepal with deadly consequences in particular. The book with an impressive cover, entitled NEPALMAA BHRASTAACHAAR: KAARAN RA NIBAARAN, can roughly be translated as Corruption in Nepal: Causes and Prevention.

Seen as a logical output of serious research, study, and interest in the area, the voluminous book is divided into eight major chapters along with appendices, a picture gallery, and quite a comprehensive 36-page bibliography, mostly in English. One basic attribute of the book is the telltale details of the corrupt behaviours of various people. Those who read the book thoroughly can't remain unimpressed with the last two pages dealing with what is called a resume of corruption, tracing its tentative birth dating back to almost 300 BC.

Chapter one categorises five types, forms, and levels of corruption, including policy-level corruption normally practiced as a protective shield to save people from indulging in such acts, along with normative criteria and definitions. The second chapter deals with the corruption index vis-à-vis Nepal's status. Chapter three deals at length with the theoretical and practical aspects of corruption as a social, economic, and political malaise.

The biggest chapter of the book is the fourth, which seeks to specifically portray the causes and reasons of corruption, even citing major cases of sheer anomalies involved. Linked to this are chapters seven and eight that depict endeavours against the evil and suggestions and recommendations to control visibly rampant corruption in the country, respectively. Chapter five seeks to deal with what can be called the ill-effects of corruption. The remaining chapter six essentially seeks to highlight global efforts to control corruption.

One disturbing aspect of corruption in Nepal is the visibly perceived impression by people both inside and outside the country that the menace has constantly mushroomed with a tinge of impunity after the political change supposed to foster democratic culture and promote socio-economic transformation through efficient and judicious utilisation of internal and external resources.



NEPALMAA BHRASTAACHAAR: KAARAN RA NIBAARAN
Ram Kumar Acharya
Publishers: Ram Kumar Acharya, Kathmandu, 2023,
Pages 494,
Price: Rs. 875/-

As a reflection of his 32-year-long experience in legal service and close observations of the working modality of organisations and bodies expressly dedicated to controlling corruption, including the judiciary and the Commission for Investigation of Abuse of Authority, Nepal's Ombudsman type of constitutional organ, Acharya finds a state of dilemma and even a double standard pervading Nepali society as everyone talks of controlling the vice but takes little interest in going through its cause and effect, not to mention the quite distant issue of controlling it.

The well-researched book is possibly the second such attempt by a senior bureaucrat after former Secretary Sharad Chandra Paudel's similar but still bigger work entitled BHRASTAACHAAR: KAARAN, PARINAAM RA NIYANTRANKAA UPAAYA (Corruption: Causes, Effects, and Measures towards its Eradication) that hit bookstalls more than two years ago.

Acharya has used a methodology to deal with the vexed issue of corruption with both historical insight and the real-time status of corruption in Nepal, with some leading examples, with a view to presenting a cogent approach as far as the theoretical and practical aspects of corruption in our context are concerned.

Besides, the new book has incorporated commentaries by popular figures spread over a wider compass, like actively practicing politician Gagan Kumar Thapa, senior economist Dr. Swarnim Wagle, who caught international limelight after his resounding success in the Tanahun by-election, then Chief Secretary Dr. Somlal Subedi, and a senior journalist writing on corruption, Hari Bahadur Thapa.

Acharya has also tried to convey his message to readers in the form of various dos and don'ts and taken care to cover a wide range of stakeholders and the erosion that has taken place in our social value system and normative behaviour over several decades. His field, which can be called the command area, is wider to include all aspects of corruption, including historical legacy, the preponderance of corruption-friendly legal rules and regulations, and the politicisation of constitutional and judicial councils supposed to become vanguards of anti-corruption activities.

Acharya tries to depict and expose varied areas and tools of corruption that have now been discussed in public with satirical derision. These include an advance payment system for contractors, a loss of quality in bureaucracy, overpoliticization, a corrupt and costly election system, political parties and their leadership, proportional representation, weak norms for good conduct and behaviour, corrupt leadership, an unequal and discriminatory educational system in practice, etc.

One discerningly notable aspect is that Acharya has used a comprehensive quantum of references and source materials in his quite detailed presentation, with emphasis on a vast range of foreign publications and topical reports, to highlight his concerns about the rather thriving phenomenon of corruption in Nepal. He has also made use of a number of our own sources, including articles available in both print and web media.

However, it is quite difficult to understand why he has not thought it prudent to make reference to a large volume on the same subject written by Secretary Sharad Chandra Paudel, as already mentioned above.

Another lacuna of the otherwise comprehensive book is the plethora of proofreading mistakes. Likewise, there are some instances relating to the Nepali context that seem to have been directly culled from newspapers. The sheer volume of the work might have prevented the author from processing and refining it properly.

Despite such seemingly unavoidable and minor pitfalls, I congratulate Acharya on his wonderful contributions, despite lingering apathy on the part of readers on the very subject of corruption. This is in the context of a lack of seriousness among stakeholders to squarely deal with the subject that has significantly eroded our credibility in the community of nations, including among our development partners and international organisations that have shown interest in assisting us in improving the quality of life.

(Dr. Bhattarai is a former Foreign Secretary, ambassador, and author; kutniti@gmail.com.)

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FUTURE WATCH

(Based on birth names)

January 12th to 18th 2024 - D. N. Lohani

ARIES — Success without struggle is unlikely. Income will be lower than expected, but you will handle the situation. Students will have to work harder. Philanthropic sentiment will prevail. The family will provide good support towards the end.

TAURUS — Fear and confusion can reside within oneself. Circumstances will improve starting Sunday. Prevailing fear and confusion can reside within oneself. Relatives will provide good support. Trade and profession will both turn profitable.

GEMINI — The first half is ordinary. Worthless travel can occur. Expenditure will rise. Circumstances will improve starting Tuesday afternoon. Study will take a progressive course. Business can slow down.

CANCER — Travel will turn profitable. Study will take a progressive course. You will be eager to learn new subjects. Marital development will face obstacles. Study will take a progressive course.

LEO — Major days are favorable. A high level of enthusiasm will guide you ahead. Income and expenditure will maintain balance. Love and life will prosper. Decisive ability will guide you ahead.

VIRGO — Initially expenditure levels will rise. Circumstances will improve after Sunday afternoon. Students will have to work harder. Indecisiveness can create some problems. With some effort, employees will observe productive periods. The business will turn profitable.

LIBRA — The period until Monday will contain challenges. A health disorder is predicted. The expenditure level will rise. circumstances will improve from Tuesday. Major tasks will be completed successfully. Social prestige won't rise. You will win on legal issues. The business will turn profitable.

SCORPIO — A high level of determination will guide you ahead. Health disorders are predicted during the mid-portion. Trade and profession will both turn profitable. Students will have to work harder.

SAGITTARIUS — Handle valuable goods during the first two days. Major tasks will be completed successfully on Sunday evening. You will be attracted to a new subject. Income and expenditure will maintain balance.

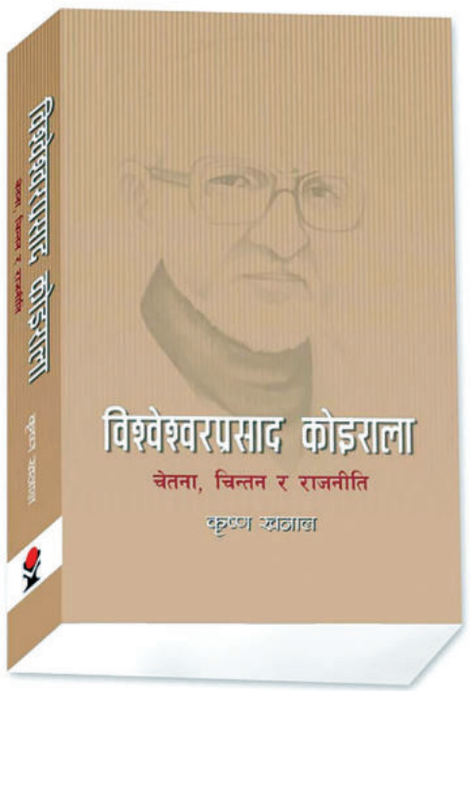
CAPRICORN — An entertaining week is in the store. You will meet interesting people during the initial period. Expenditure will go beyond your expectations. Foreign trade will yield a return. Some of you may have to travel abroad.

AQUARIUS — The expenditure level will rise. Trade and profession will both turn profitable. Travel and recreational events will occur. You will be keen to learn new trades or travel. Friends and family will cooperate.

PISCES — An advantageous week is in the store. A ray of hope will emerge. Regular gain will provide a return. Expenditure will surpass income. Studying will keep you busy. Family problems will disappear. Business will advance.

BOOK REVIEW

A Revive On BP's Thoughts





Gandhi Raj Kafle

Bishweshwor Prasad Koirala: Chetana, Chintan Ra Rajneeti (Bishweshwor Prasad Koirala: Conscience, Vision, and Politics), by Krishna Khanal, published by Oriental Publication House, price: 1150.00,
ISBN: 978-9937-9608 – 0 – 9.

What makes a leader memorable? Many arguments can be made about it. But if we let the nation make some images of such personalities on its own, there will be only a few to remember. But why is it that many leaders, who make big promises and say they'll do great things for their countries, end up not being remembered in the long run, despite reaching the highest levels of power?

In casual conversations, we might not fully understand how serious this concern is. Some may say, "Why should we be concerned if many leaders fail or disappear from the political scene?" This argument might seem valid in our discussion. However, becoming statesmen who are remembered positively for their impact on societies in the long run isn't something that just any Tom, Dick, and Harry in politics can accomplish. It's not a task for every average person in the political arena.

But there is also a circle of scholars whose genuine concerns exist. Here we find some scholars who think, float ideas, search for the cause of deficiency in national politics, and warn everyone not to deviate from the moral path of governance. Recently, Professor Krishna Khanal has made one such praiseworthy academic exercise, which not only discusses the issues of making statesmen but also shows a broad canvass for everyone to be alert to all the temptations of selfish politics.

Professor Khanal enters the topic, and the personality for him to do research on it is B. P. Koirala himself. His book title in Nepali is the two-word name "Bishweshworprasad Koirala.". However, under these two big font words on the cover page, there are also three other smaller font words: Chetana, Chintan, and Rajniti, which highlight all the themes on the topic "Bishweshworprasad'. Outwardly, these three words may seem to readers that they are used by the author only to describe B. P. Koirala's personality, but the intrinsic sense of the use is not so. They are more relevant to present and future times also because no one can imagine making or developing visionary leadership if politics is delinked from Chetana and Chintan (conscience and vision).

The author has divided this study into eleven chapters. Chapter one is "Chetana Ra Chintan" (Conscience and Vision), and the last one is "Lokatantra, Sambaidhanik Abhyas Ra Rajneeti" (Inclusive Democracy, Constitutional Practice, and Politics). Between these two themes, there are many events: the process of political awakenings, the revolution of 1951 AD, and the movements of restoration of democracy to the journey of the nation to institutionalise republican set up through the successful practice of the Constituent Assembly.

So, this book is wide, even from the point of view of time. B. P. Koirala emerged as a prime leader during the time of the revolution in 1951 AD, and it has already been more than four decades since his demise. He struggled for democracy throughout his life and remained uncompromised for democratic values, even with kings. Beyond doubt, these things are inspiring.

But these things were not the prime motive for author Krishna Khanal to produce this insightful book. His real surprise for him to write this voluminous 591-page book is the question of why B.P. Koirala, who floated the idea of national reconciliation to bring monarchy into the constitutional framework, has been continuously referred to and remembered even in post-republican governance in the country.

Professor Khanal's findings in this book, however, are optimistic. He emphasises that BP. Koirala has been remembered in a symbolic sense, too. This means the country is still in need of a visionary leader.

But is it possible for leaders to act with this vision and become leaders like this? The first three chapters of this book are very important in the search for this kind of leadership.

B.P. Koirala faced significant challenges in his family background, reflecting the struggles endured by his father, Krishna Prasad Koirala. Despite these hardships, he had the opportunity to receive a liberal education and actively participated in the Indian independence movement. Engaging with prominent Indian leaders like Jawaharlal Nehru, Jayaprakash Narayan, and Dr. Rajendra Prasad during the fight against British rule further shaped his life.

But the main point, as mentioned by Khanal in this book, should not be seen only in this background. The author is convinced to say that all such values are mere themes of background. The real secret is that BP Koirala himself was the creator of his personality.

The inspiring point, therefore, is that the road to walk ahead in this vision and rise above the petty interests of societies or groups to enhance national glory in a new republican setup in Nepal is open to all leaders.

According to Professor Khanal BP Koirala's intact remembrance even after more than four decades of his demise, this is a testimony to the trust of the people of Nepal in visionary leadership to act and deliver good governance in the country. Will someone come up this way? The book offers insights in detail.

(Kafle is a former Deputy Executive Editor of this daily)

AI's Revolution In Film Editing



Bharat Regmi

Storytelling and human experience are at the core of what editors do, and nowhere are these elements more present than in the field of film editing. At their heart, films are stories about people, their struggles, and their outer transformation. Crafting a compelling narrative on a timeline requires a deep understanding of story structure, pacing, and the filmmaking process. Editing is the backbone of filmmaking and some percent of directing because the editor is recreating and rewriting the post. A well-edited film can elevate the story, pacing, mood, performance, and themes.

In the early days of film, editing was a manual process involving physical film reels. After the decade of 2000, editing underwent a digital transformation. The digital transformation in Nepal started in 2007 with the Kagbeni movie. Released in 2008, Kagbeni is Nepal's first digital film, which was shot by a camera that was not fully functional. It became a great opportunity for creative professionals, including directors, actors, cinematographers, and editors, to experiment with digital transformation. Digital cameras revolutionised the film industry by making hard drive storage and digital editing possible for feature films. Software such as Adobe Premiere, Final Cut, and Avid allows editors to easily rearrange scenes for nonlinear editing. Software has come a long way to help with editing such as cuts, transitions, and colour correction.

Now, after 2020, another digital revolution is taking place, which is rapidly increasing as it can do the entire work of filmmaking itself. Some critics have started saying that there will be no need to shoot movies within a few years. All created by artificial intelligence. Art, scenery, characters, editing, colour grading, everything—even the film itself—is made by AI. Film director Pranab Joshi is working on AI and experiencing its innovations in every dimension. He says, "The introduction of AI in the film industry marks a significant shift, showcasing glimpses of it's potential through tools. Innovations such as video editing tools' new updates and the emergence of tools that can translate videos into any language hint at a transformative future where entire movies can be created from the comfort of a room without the need for traditional cameras."

The AI industry, already valued at 136.6 billion dollars, is reshaping the filmmaking experience across different stages, from pre-production to post-production. AI's capacity to analyse vast datasets can provide valuable insights and generate stunning graphics, transporting audiences to imaginative realms. Moreover, AI assists in creative processes, offering ideas, character development, dialogue improvement, and content refinement. So, it has already begun to impact filmmaking and editing. There are three huge benefits to editing. One is reducing the amount of time spent on editing. Another one is the ability to make micro-adjustments that might be difficult for a human. And another one is that AI can act as an assistant editor, allowing editors to focus on more creative tasks. Among the editing tools in Premiere, the Auto Reframe tool automatically identifies focal points within a frame and adjusts aspect ratios to suit different platforms, making it especially useful for filmmakers who want to produce trailers for social media. Similarly, Speech to Text offers AI transcription services, converting spoken dialogue into text subtitles. However, the Colour Match tool matches colour grades between different shots, helping to maintain consistent looks throughout their project. In addition, AI removes unwanted objects from clips, analyses audio tracks, and balances the mix. AI allows you to create complete videos from text descriptions. As we describe a scene, this tool will create a video of it on the spot. Filmmaker Joshi says, "The efficiency gains are further extended to film editing, with AI tools streamlining processes and enhancing footage quality. As the industry witnesses the continuous influx of new AI tools, the trajectory suggests that AI will become



ubiquitous, revolutionising various aspects of filmmaking. While these advancements bring forth exciting possibilities, they also raise concerns about potential job displacement and the impact on traditional filmmaking practices."

However, editing is not just about cutting clips together; it's a deep art of the story's timing, mood, and emotion understanding. Editor's choices are at the foundation of craft. Turning raw footage into a narrative of the editor's decisions, each of which has the potential to impact the pace, sequence, and tone of the story. Film editing is as much about storytelling as it is about technical skills. Editors understand the feelings between characters through precise timing. This requires a level of understanding of human behaviour that AI has yet to reach. Many professionals say that AI-generated results are a good starting point, but additional editor input is usually needed for the final touches. The role of AI in editing is that it acts as an advanced tool that can handle the more monotonous aspects of the job, freeing editors to focus on creative decisions. This could be useful for dialogue editing or temporary voice-over work before final recording.

The BFI London Film Festival in London had an 'I AM NOT A ROBOT' session about generative AI in the screen industries, organised in collaboration with Screen International. In the session, Tim Weber, CEO of UK-based animation and visual effects company Framestore, says, "Generative AI is not as effective as first thought. It's neither as revelatory and amazing as we all thought it might be in the early days, nor is it as scary as we all thought it might be in the early days. We're crossing somewhere in the middle."

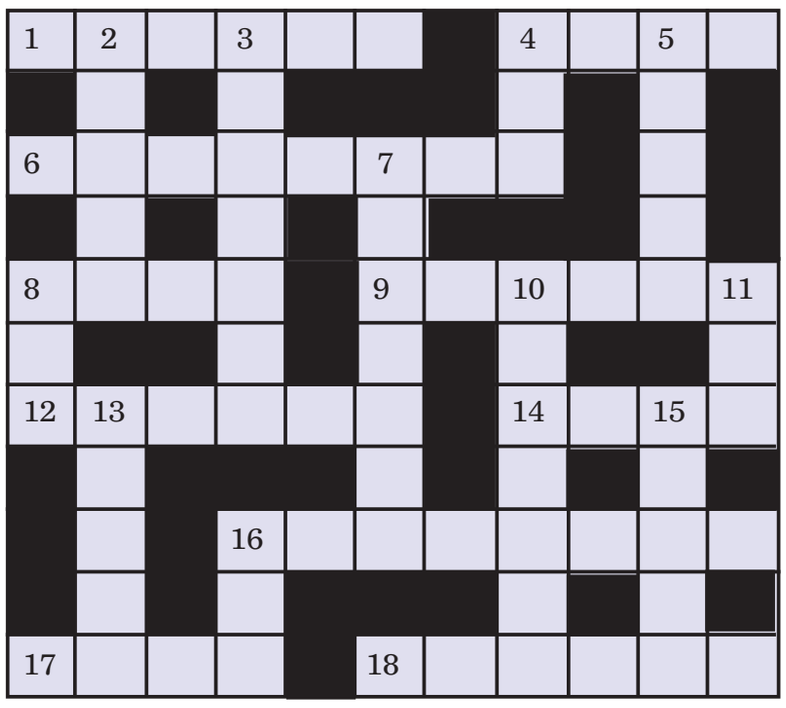
Also on the panel was Sami Arpa, CEO of Swiss-based AI company Largo, who unveiled a new AI storyboarding tool that allows for more 'style consistent" creations. "While traditional storyboarding often relies on generic images and is a time-consuming process, the new AI tool uses highly specialised production to create specific styles. Production companies can now benefit from the power of AI-assisted storyboarding, making the creative process more efficient and accessible," Arpa says.

In my opinion, AI may devalue the art of storyboarding and editing in film, although it seems unlikely that AI will overtake creative and intelligent humans. Technology has not reached the point where it can replicate the artistry and creative intuition that humans bring. But now the debate is going on about whether the film will be made by AI. Artists will do it all with AI. If so, what about human emotions? What about human expression? Could it represent humans' inner feelings, ethical reflections, and cultural nuances? Could it make a moral impression? These questions help us think more deeply about the role and value of human creativity in an increasingly automated world. Theatre artist, film director, and writer Kedar Shrestha says, "I don't believe that AI will make movies and create emotions and thoughts." The Oscar-winning visual effects supervisor Tim Weber at the BFI's industry panel says, 'Using generative AI for video is much more difficult than for images. The big issue is temporal stability. Getting and controlling the style you want is one of the hardest things. They're not very directed. They're not very controlled." He added, "Actors are not hired for their faces. We are recruiting actors based on their performance, their personalities, and what they bring in terms of character. We create a lot of characters, but bringing that character to life and getting someone to carry the film is a completely different challenge."

Aside from these challenges, AI might introduce unemployment and dwindling opportunities for emerging professionals in the creative journey. Art captures the inner feelings, ethical reflections, cultural nuances, and other subtleties of the creator, but automation might streamline the process of filmmaking and reduce costs as well as the emotional richness of the outcome. Technology and art never stand still. What is AI capable of doing today, and what can it do tomorrow? None of us can say.

(The author is a film editor.)

TRN CROSSWORD PUZZLE NO. 1773



Name .....

Address .....

Signature .....

Last date of entry:
January 17, 2024

Win a prize of Rs. 600. In case there are more than one correct entry the prize will be split into three sums of Rs. 200 each. The winner will be selected by a lucky draw. Only cuttings (not photo copy) that include the Crossword Puzzle no. will be accepted.

Across

1. An evil practice had to control
4. Register your vote
6. The money possessed by a company
8. Unexpected drawback
9. Make it possible for
12. Time of intense difficulty
14. Keep annoying
16. You get free information from them
17. A thrust with knife
18. An official treaty

Down

2. You are one
3. Allegations
4. Because
5. Reveal confidential information to someone
7. Chalk landing place
8. A very short time
10. Good, kind and beautiful
11. A person's death
13. A machine controlled by computer
15. Dayahang Rai is one
16. Hit a ball in a high arc

Solutions to TRN Crossword Puzzle No. 1772

ACROSS: 1. UPDATE 4. JOLT 6. BACKSTAB 8. DATA 9. WEALTH 12. EVADER 14. ALSO 16. PEDIGREE 17. EDIT 18. REMARK

DOWN: 2. PLAZA 3. AWKWARD 4. JAB 5. LEAST 7. TOWERED 8. DIE 10. AMALGAM 11. HBO 13. VALID 15. STEER 16. PIT

LUCKY WINNER

Radheshyam Shrestha
Damodar Lohani
Surya Shakya

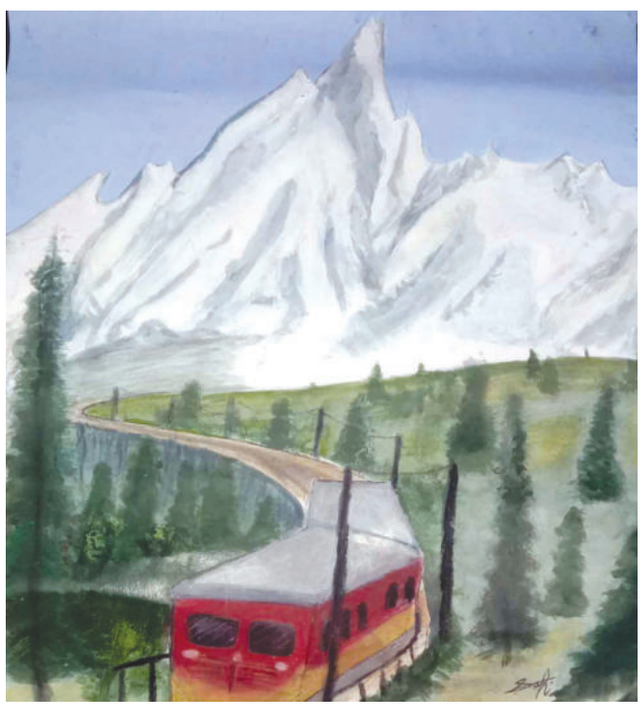
ALL CORRECT ANSWER

Bal Krishna Shrestha, Krishna Chandra Gautam, Sunil Sharma Bhattarai, Archana Devi Shrestha

CREATIVE CORNER



Brisha Wagle, Grade: II, The Chandbagh School



Saanvi Karkee, Grade VII, Campain School, Lagenkhel, Lalitpur

TRN PUZZLE NUMBER-405

All you have to do is to fill up in the seven boxes below with the numbers in such a way that the sum will be 462 whether you go diagonally, horizontally or vertically. The numbers should be 42 to 90 between. The number should not be used twice.

71	80	89		51	60	69
79	88	48		59	68	70
46	55	57	66	75	77	86
		65			85	
		73			44	
63	72	81	90	43	52	61

84	93	102	55	64	73	82
92	101	61	63	72	81	83
100	60	62	71	80	89	91
59	68	70	79	88	90	99
67	69	78	87	96	98	58
75	77	86	95	97	57	66
76	85	94	103	56	65	74

TRN PUZZLE SOLUTION-404

Prepared by: Bishwo Nath Kharel

Gandhi's Influential Journey



Kashyap Gautam

On October 2nd, 1969, Karamchand Gandhi had a son from his fourth wife, Putlibai. His name was Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, or he was later known by the world as Mahatma Gandhi. Mohandas was the youngest child, having one elder sister and two elder brothers. Born into a simple family, he looked like the simplest of boys and was about to influence the whole world with his rebellious virtues and tactics. While the whole world chose violence, Mahatma Gandhi chose words.

The early days were nothing special, as it was like any other school life story—mocking teachers and calling them names. But he was otherwise a very shy introvert, and he used to avoid fame and the spotlight as much as he could. He instead chose books as his mates.

Even from his childhood days, he always embraced the truth, always speaking the truth despite the consequences he would have to face later. He was a simple young lad with the qualities of respecting the elders, loving the youngers, and bonding with the people of his age. He always acknowledged his teachers, relatives, friends, and companions.

But two plays made him set two new rules throughout his life. In the play of Shravana, he carries a sling on his shoulder, carrying his blind parents. This gave him a motive to take care of his parents until his last breath. Another is about Harishchandra, where he always speaks the truth despite the pain and consequences he might face later.

Mahatma Gandhi married at the age of 13, which he thinks was a disturbing and incorrect happening in his life. He did not hate Kasturbai (Gandhi's wife), but disliked child marriage in general. Actually, he thought of her as a simple and preservative woman.

Gandhi's family was a pure vegetarian, and so was he. But Gandhi's friend Mahtab manipulated and dragged Mohandas to eat meat, as Mahtab deceived him into believing that meat was the only way to become strong. He used to consume goat meat. He had done this, breaking his father's faith in him. Then he thought and came to the conclusion that it was wrong and should not be continued. However, it was not the end of deceiving others. He used to smoke the cigarettes thrown away by his relatives clandestinely.

Gandhi's marriage life was not easy. When he was sixteen, his father died. However, the death happened at the most rare and unusual time possible. As Gandhi notes, it happened when Kasturbai and Gandhiji were having sex. This incident left him in trauma until his last moments and brought hatred towards sex into his mind.

Now, with his father dead, he was the main man of the house and decided to go to England with three virtues: never touching another woman, wine, and meat. Gandhi went to London to study law. Nevertheless, the adaptation wasn't easy; he wore a hat, learned their dance, and learned to play the violin. He also visited the Eiffel Tower. He returned in 1891 to work in the high court of Bombay. He found out that his mother had died while he was in London. Later, he left Bombay for Rajkot and set up his office there, where his brother lived. In 1893, he got a contract from South Africa for a court case. He accepted it and went on a new adventure in a new country. South Africa, where he experienced various forms of racial discrimination. The three most famous incidents are: first, he was thrown from his first-class train seat only because he was an Indian. Second, he was forced to take off his 'pagdi' while fighting the court case in South Africa. Third, in his hotel, he was commanded to eat his dinner in his room because only white people deserved the dinner tables, despite both races paying the prices equally.

After these oppressive experiences that he faced, he started some protests with some other Indians as well. He went back to India after some months to take his wife and sons with him. He continued protesting and influencing people with his lifestyle. Later, he was invited to India again, and thus he went back.

Gandhi's speeches were powerful and convinced many to adopt a non-violent protest called Satyagraha. This approach later influenced Nelson Mandela too. Satyagraha was nothing but a movement where you are not supposed to claim or win something using your physical strength but rather by tolerating and using your words.

He also used another movement while fighting for India's independence. In this movement, Indians were requested to only use products that were Indian-made and to boycott British products, which came with a heavy amount of tax. Gandhi led a famous event called the Salt March, where Indians collected their own salt instead of buying it from the English, showing opposition to British control.

After World War II, England was slowly getting weaker and losing land and men. That is why, on August 15th, 1947, India gained its independence and became an independent country. Gandhi was a phenomenon. From a normal boy to the greatest Indian personality, let us use his teachings in our lives as well.